



PREVENTIVE MEASURES

SC suggests steps to curb sexual offences in Delhi

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India to boost defence ties with Switzerland

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WIDENING GAPS

The looming crisis of world unemployment

The Global South faces an unprecedented challenge

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Jamil's India faces Forlan's Uruguay

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IN BRIEF



Set up SIT to probe bulk filing of Form 7: Telangana Cong.

HYDERABAD
The Telangana Congress has approached Hyderabad Police alleging a bid to remove voters from electoral rolls through pre-filled Form 7 applications during the ongoing special intensive revision. » Page 5

W.B. re-enrolment drive: BLOs seek security cover

KOLKATA
An association of BLOs in West Bengal on Monday wrote to the CEO seeking security cover during the survey to enrol new voters and re-enrol eligible voters whose names were deleted during the SIR drive. » Page 4

Further demands on India-U.S. deal ‘very difficult’: Sitharaman

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Negotiations for the India-U.S. trade deal have reached a “plateau”, where it will now be “very difficult” to add to the list of demands and concessions that have been agreed to, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday.
Speaking at the Munich Leaders Meeting here, Ms. Sitharaman said that India’s imports of Russian oil did not feature as a condition during the negotiations for its free trade agreement (FTA) with the European Union, which is set to be signed in December.
“One thing about the U.S. agreement, which is yet to get finalised, it has been a hard and very rigorously negotiated agreement,” the Finance Minister said. “The negotiations are still ongoing but we would like to believe that



Nirmala Sitharaman

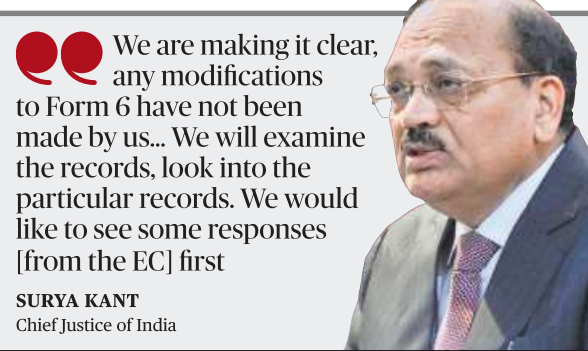
both sides have reached a plateau beyond which giving or taking might be very difficult.”
She added that a predominant feature of the India-U.S. trade relationship is that India has a substantial trade surplus, something the U.S. is looking to address.
“The trade imbalance with China for India, for instance, since 2014 has been growing exponentially,” the Union Finance Minister said.
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SC distances itself from Form 6 tweaks, issues notice to EC

Plea seeks suspension of CEC over allegations of bias, overreach during SIR; court takes note of post-retirement immunity for top poll officials

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday distanced itself from the controversial alterations made to Form 6 for registering new voters during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across several States, shifting scrutiny to the Election Commission (EC).
“We are making it clear, any modifications to Form 6 have not been made by us... We will examine the records, look into the particular records. We would like to see some responses [from the EC] first”
Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of the Bench, pointed to how the CEC and Election Commissioners continue to enjoy immunity



sioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over allegations of bias, administrative unilateralism, and procedural overreach during the SIR process.
Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of the Bench, pointed to how the CEC and Election Commissioners continue to enjoy immunity from legal proceedings even after demitting office, a protection not available to even judges.
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VOTERS TO MISS BYPOLLS
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ILLEGAL CHANGE: RAHUL
» PAGE 11

Trio wins medicine Nobel for ‘controlling’ neurons with light

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A trio of scientists was on Monday declared the winners of the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine for discoveries leading to a technique called optogenetics, which allows scientists to control select nerve cells using light.
The Nobel Assembly said the work of the laureates – Karl Deisseroth, Peter Hegemann, and Georg Nagel – allowed neuroscience to move beyond observing correlations and testing how particular neurons and neural circuits are related to different behaviours and emotions. Today, optogenetics helps scientists study schizophrenia, depression, Alzheimer’s and Parkinson’s diseases, and test treatments to restore vision and hearing loss.
In the 1990s, Mr. Hegemann, now at Humboldt

Bright minds

The trio won the Nobel for contributions towards **optogenetics**, which helps in the study of schizophrenia, depression, and Alzheimer’s disease



University in Berlin, and his team found that shining light on a microscopic alga called Chlamydomonas rapidly triggered an electric signal within its body.
CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

‘Hasina’s activities pose challenge to planning Bangladesh PM’s India trip’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
DHAKA

Minister for Foreign Affairs of Bangladesh Humaiyun

Kobir said on Monday that the activities of deposed premier Sheikh Hasina and her team pose the “principal challenge” to planning

a visit to India by Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman.
DETAILS ON
» PAGE 12

Will not stay proceedings against Nicobar project, says SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Saying that “preservation of culture is a constitutionally protected fundamental right”, the Supreme Court on Monday refused to agree with a Union government plea to stay Calcutta High Court proceedings in a petition challenging the Great Nicobar Island Project. A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant instead urged the Calcutta High Court to hear the case and decide the issues without delay.
Appearing for the Centre, Attorney-General R. Venkataramani and Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati said the project worth ₹72,000 crore was of “immense” national importance and strategic value. Mr. Venkataramani said there was “no loss of habitation” for the indigenous tribal population like the endangered Shompen tribe of the Great Nicobar Island.
‘NGT gave clearance’
Ms. Bhati submitted that the National Green Tribunal (NGT) had already twice disposed of the apprehensions raised regarding the project. It had cleared the environmental clearance given to the project, subject to conditions and the formation of a high-powered committee to re-examine specific ecological impacts.
She said even a review against the environmental clearance was rejected by the NGT subsequently in April 2023.
CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

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2020 riots: HC rejects petitions seeking FIRs over ‘hate speeches’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Monday refused to direct the registration of FIRs against several political leaders over alleged hate speeches during the 2020 north-east Delhi riots, observing that the record indicated an element of “political selectivity” in the manner in which certain individuals and speeches had been singled out for action.

The court also declined to order an SIT or independent probe into the riots, holding that the petitions did not disclose any exceptional circumstance warranting “extraordinary judicial intervention”.

No to ‘excesses’ at Jamia

In separate pleas concerning the December 2019 violence at Jamia Millia Islamia, the court refused to order an inquiry into alleged police excesses.

Hearing a batch of petitions filed in 2019 and 2020 over the alleged speeches, a Bench of Justices Vivek Chaudhary and Manoj Jain observed that, in several instances, only excerpts of the purported speeches had been placed on record.

The leaders mentioned in the petitions included Bharatiya Janata Party’s Anurag Thakur, Parvesh Sahib Singh, and Kapil Mishra; Congress’s Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi, and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra; and Aam Aadmi Party’s Manish Sisodia and Amanatullah Khan.

Regarding the investigation into the riots, the court noted that allegations against individual police officers could not by themselves establish that the entire investigative machinery of the Delhi police was incapable of conducting a fair investigation.

The Bench noted that 757 criminal cases had been registered in connection with the riots. As of February 19, 2026, investigation had been handed over to the Crime Branch in 65 cases, charge sheets had been filed in 369 cases, proceedings in 212 cases were pending before criminal courts, and 249 cases remained under probe.

Rejecting the plea for a fresh inquiry into the violence at Jamia Millia Islamia, the court said the police did not enter the university premises at the outset to deal with an otherwise peaceful assembly confined to the campus.

ACP accused of ‘molesting’ journalist gets promotion; why afraid of women: Rahul

A routine promotion request was sent way back: police; LoP questions Amit Shah and Delhi Police, demands justice for all those who faced ‘violence’ at Jantar Mantar and action against guilty officers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) Vivek Bhagat, who has been accused of molesting a woman journalist during a protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar at Jantar Mantar, was on Monday promoted to the rank of Additional Deputy Commissioner, along with 11 others, according to an order signed by the Deputy Secretary (Home) Ramesh Kumar.

A senior police officer said these were routine promotions and a request for the same was sent way back.

The Crime Branch, to which three complaints alleging sexual harassment and manhandling by police personnel were transferred on Sunday, had not registered an FIR in any of the cases by Monday evening, nearly 48 hours after the alleged incidents.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday ac-



Protesters staging a sit-in outside the Parliament Street police station on Monday following allegations of harassment of women by Delhi Police personnel. ANI

cus ed Delhi Police of following a pattern of “silencing women who dare to ask questions” and demanded justice for all those who have faced “violence and misbehaviour” at the hands of police personnel.

In a post on X, Mr. Gandhi also targeted Union Home Minister Amit Shah, saying, “Why are you and your police so afraid of women?” His remarks accompanied a video of his recent interaction with journalists Shaheen Khan and Nafisa Khan, who accused Delhi Police of assaulting them

inside the Saket police station a few weeks ago while they were covering an event attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Mr. Shah. The two women alleged that they were forcibly taken to the police station and beaten up.

“What’s happening in Delhi right now follows a single pattern: silence any woman who dares to ask questions,” Mr. Gandhi wrote.

Referring to the recent protests at Jantar Mantar, he said hundreds of people were detained while wo-

men protesters alleged misbehaviour by male police personnel. He also alleged that cameras were snatched from women journalists and they were dragged away while no FIR was registered on the journalists’ complaint against Mr. Bhagat.

The Congress leader said Ms. Shaheen and Ms. Nafisa recounted to him their alleged mistreatment inside the Saket police station. “Think about it - inside the station, the very place where women go to file complaints,” Mr. Gandhi said.

‘Release CCTV footage’

Those entrusted with protecting women were themselves posing a threat to them, he said, demanding that the entire CCTV footage from the Saket police station incident be made public and immediate action be taken against police personnel found guilty.

(With inputs from PTI)

JOURNALISTS BOOKED
» PAGE 10

‘Fear of jail won’t work’: CJP says it will go ahead with October 10 protest

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Monday said it will go ahead with its October 10 protest call at Jantar Mantar against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, asserting that its mobilisation should be seen as a “broader call by the youth” rather than that of a particular outfit.

Welcoming the INDIA bloc’s planned protest against the CEC and ‘vote chori’ (election theft) on Tuesday, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said, “We welcome all peaceful protests. Everyone should make efforts, be it INDIA bloc or other student organisations or activists, or common people. Everyone needs to assert their rights.”

Describing Jantar Mantar as a “symbol of hope, victory and shared responsibility”, the CJP said the march would remain peaceful even if protesters are prevented by Delhi Police from reaching the designated site. “Wherever the police stop us, we will sit there and that will become Jantar Mantar. They cannot cordon off the entire city, right?” Mr. Das said at a press conference.

He also said the CJP had received information from



CJP spokesperson Saurav Das addressing mediapersons in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

“well-wishers” within the establishment that its leaders could be arrested ahead of the October 10 protest.

“It does not matter if we are arrested or detained... Fear of FIR, fear of jail won’t work anymore,” Mr. Das said.

AAP preparation

Meanwhile, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) asked various organisations supporting the October 10 protest against the CEC to prepare back-up leadership and communication plans in case their leaders are detained.

Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj held meetings with party MLAs, councillors, district presidents, and ward observers and said leaders of various outfits supporting Jantar Mantar 2.0 could “soon be arrested in false cases”.

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SCHOOL BUZZ

TECH SYMPOSIUM HELD



Ahlcon Public School's Souvenir Club hosted 'Silico Battles v22.1', their flagship inter-school technology symposium, drawing 32 schools and over 300 students from across Delhi NCR. Principal Dr. Deepak Raj Singh Bisht delivered the welcome address, encouraging participants to innovate and excel. Students competed in 15 technology-driven events, including Programming, RoboWars, Drone Race and CyQuest, judged by a panel of alumni and professionals. DPS Indirapuram emerged Overall Champion, while Apeejay School, Noida, won the Runners-up Trophy. Lakshya Kargeti, President, Souvenir Club, proposed the vote of thanks.

INTER-SCHOOL FEST HELD

Bal Bharati Public School, Rohini, hosted Explorika, an inter-school festival themed 'Vidya, Vivek, Vikas', bringing together learners from over 37 schools across India. Students took part in a diverse array of competitions, including Digital Storyboard and App Development to hone digital skills, Young Innovators and Future Fusion for future-ready skills, and Sanskrit Natika and Samanvaya, a dance event, reviving languages in line with NEP 2020. The festival underscored the school's philosophy of nurturing knowledge, discernment, integrity and social sensitivity.

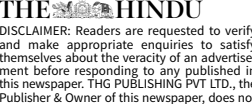


AUTHOR INTERACTION HELD



Seth Anandram Jaipuria School, Kanpur, hosted 'A Morning with Amish — The World of Dhruv-Tara', featuring author Mr. Amish Tripathi, who was felicitated by Mr. Ganesh Tiwari, Principal. Mr. Tripathi presented the trailer of his book 'Dhruv-Tara & The Great Indian History Quiz' and conducted an interactive quiz, with five winners receiving gifts. The session continued with a podcast and Q&A, before concluding with a vote of thanks by Mrs. Madhushree Bhaumik, Vice Principal-Junior, and an autograph session.

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Consider Gymkhana Club plea, SC tells HC

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Delhi High Court to consider a plea by 11 members of the Delhi Gymkhana Club challenging the Centre’s decision to take over 27.3 acres of land leased to the club and the subsequent eviction proceedings.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana was apprised by senior advocate Vikas Singh, appearing for the club members, that the High Court had refused to entertain their plea on the grounds that only the

club could challenge the Centre’s decision. Mr. Singh said the High Court had asked the members to seek a clarification from the apex court on whether they could also move the plea. The top court allowed them to move the High Court, subject to objections that may be raised by the other side regarding maintainability and other legal issues.

The club members alleged that the government’s actions constituted a “colourable exercise” of power and violated their fundamental rights under Articles 14 and 19, besides depriving them of property contrary to Article 300A of the Constitution.

Step up stray dog sterilisation, HC tells civic bodies

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Monday directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the New Delhi Municipal Council to coordinate with the Lucknow Municipal Corporation (LMC) and organise train-

ing camps for veterinarians, para-veterinarians, and dog catchers to accelerate stray dog sterilisation in the Capital.

A Bench of Justices Dinesh Mehta and Aditi Choudhary noted that the LMC had agreed to send personnel to Delhi for a 15-day training programme

CISF constable attacked at protest; one detained

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) constable suffered a minor injury to his right elbow on Monday after a protester allegedly attacked him with a knife during a National Students’ Union of India protest near Jantar Mantar, the police said.

The protesters were demanding the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over SIR “irregularities”.

The constable, identified as Bikram Kumar, was taking a protester away from a barricade when the man allegedly attacked him with a knife, a CISF of-



A CISF constable showing an abrasion on his elbow after an alleged attack on Monday. ANI

ficer said. The police took Mr. Kumar to RML Hospital for treatment, and he was later discharged.

“The protester was detained and legal action is being initiated,” the paramilitary officer said, adding that the police are collecting relevant evidence, including CCTV footage.

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Anantapuramu town ...Plaintiff
And
SUDHA RAJESH AND ANOTHER ...Defendants
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RISE 06:18 SET 17:59
RISE 03:50 SET 16:33

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	max	min
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Safdarjang	36	24
Palam	35	22

Delhi Palam Today

36°C Mist and haze to occur in pleasant morning. The weather will be dry and very warm with uneasy afternoon. Night also will be pleasant.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow

37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be pleasant.

INBRIEF



Mayawati takes Akash back in BSP as national convener

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) president Mayawati on Monday announced the reappointment of Akash Anand as the party's national convener, saying the decision was taken in the interest of the party and the movement. "After considerable thought, the party has decided, in the interest of the party and the movement, to once again appoint Akash Anand as BSP's national convener and give him an opportunity to work in the party again," she wrote on X. On September 10, Ms. Mayawati had announced the ouster of Mr. Anand, her nephew, setting him "completely free" from all party responsibilities.

SC sets aside order by Bombay HC against Maharashtra FDA

The Supreme Court on Monday set aside a Bombay High Court direction ordering the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to pay ₹5 lakh in compensation to a Pune-based dairy and sweets establishment whose food licence was suspended following a food poisoning complaint. The order was passed in *State of Maharashtra & Ors. v. M/s Gurunanak Dairy & Sweets* on October 5, a press release issued by the FDA stated. The case dates to June 12, when FDA officers found deficiencies relating to hygiene, labelling and personal hygiene of employees, following which its food licence was suspended under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.

U.P. poll: tussle with SP not just over numbers but winnability of seats too, say Cong. leaders

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Amid a war of words over seat sharing for the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly election, Congress leaders on Monday said the tussle with the Samajwadi Party (SP) is not just about the number of seats but also their quality. Alleging that it is "well known that the SP tries to give difficult seats" to the Congress, they said the national party wants to secure winnable seats this time.

The two parties are partners in the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance bloc.

"Quality seats matter in any alliance. Here also [in the SP-Congress alliance], quality along with quantity will matter," Imran Masood, working president of



Quality and quantity of seats will matter, Congress leader Imran Masood said. FILE PHOTO

the State Congress unit, told *The Hindu*.

Another senior party leader said any workable framework on seat sharing must be in accordance with ground realities.

He recalled that in the 2017 poll, the Congress was given 105 seats in the alliance and won only seven. "The alliance partner will question the strike rate. But they are downplaying

the fact that out of the 100-odd seats, more than 70 were extremely difficult," the leader said, adding that many of these were urban seats or mostly represented by the BJP in the past.

The leader said a realistic approach should be taken to divide difficult seats equally and the remaining seats in the ratio of 2:1 between the SP and the Congress. He said no one can deny the appeal of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi among downtrodden social groups. This, he said, was evident from the 2024 Lok Sabha poll outcome.

The Congress said 80-odd seats in Uttar Pradesh are "difficult" for the alliance to win in light of past outcomes and social realities, while the rest are "normal". The State has a 403-member Assembly.

W.B. BLOs write to CEO, seek security ahead of drive to re-enrol voters

Names of many voters were deleted in SIR 'for no reason': BLO body to CEO Meena; it adds while they had no role in 'mass deletions', BLOs may invite wrath of those whose names were removed

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

An association of Booth Level Officers (BLOs) in West Bengal on Monday wrote to the State's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Neelam Meena seeking security arrangements during the survey to enrol new voters and re-enrol eligible voters whose names were deleted during the special intensive revision (SIR) drive ahead of the Assembly election in April.

On October 2, the Election Commission (EC) directed BLOs to visit houses across the country to enrol new voters and re-enrol eligible voters.

The association, Vote-karmi O BLO Aikya Manch, said its members would have to work in "sensitive" areas during the survey where many voters' names were deleted during the SIR, especially in eight districts – North 24 Parganas, South 24 Parganas, Howrah, Malda, Murshidabad, Uttar Dinajpur,



People whose names were removed from the roll standing outside a tribunal seeking re-inclusion of their names, in Nadia. FILE PHOTO

and parts of Hooghly and Kolkata.

"In these districts, a huge number of voters were deleted for no reason. Though the BLOs had no role in this mass deletion, they may be the target of attacks by furious deleted voters. A system [logical discrepancy] raised the question of the credentials of these deleted voters," read the letter they sent to Ms. Meena.

It added, "The BLOs

may be victims of the wrath of those deleted voters at the time of special drive. We are apprehensive of this situation."

They requested that appropriate measures be undertaken to ensure the security of the BLOs working in the sensitive areas.

The names of over 91 lakh voters were deleted from the electoral rolls in West Bengal during the SIR drive. Of these, around 27 lakh later appealed before

tribunals seeking restoration of their names.

Police officer replaced

Meanwhile, the EC on Monday replaced the Inspector-in-charge of the Nandigram police station, a day before the bypoll to the Nandigram Assembly seat, a senior officer said. Debashis Sarkar was appointed to the post, replacing Ajay Kumar Mishra.

The development comes after Opposition parties approached the EC, alleging that Mr. Mishra was close to the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party.

The State police force underwent a major reshuffle ahead of the poll. Several officers were transferred across districts as part of efforts to ensure a "transparent election process".

Nandigram played a big role in Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee's rise during the 2007-08 anti-land-grab agitation.

In 2021, she was defeated in Nandigram by Sudendu Adhikari.

(With inputs from PTI)

Rawat defies warning by Cong. brass, carries on Uttarakhand yatra

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Months before the Uttarakhand Assembly election, the Congress is facing a fresh test of discipline in the hill State, with former Chief Minister Harish Rawat deciding to continue his 'Dhanyawad evam Jansamvad Yatra' despite a clear warning from the party brass.

On Monday, Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal said it had been made clear that individual campaigns "would not be tolerated". "It was made clear that our campaigns will be taken forward jointly along with all Uttarakhand leaders, solely under the Congress banner under Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi's leadership, with the singular aim of ensuring the party's victory," said Mr. Venugopal.

Hours later, Mr. Rawat wrote in an X post in Hindi that his yatra is "heading towards Haldwani, with hundreds of vehicles moving alongside me". Earlier in the day, striking a defiant note, the 78-year-old leader wrote ahead of the Jaspur-Haldwani leg of his yatra that there would be "no looking back".

Congress general secretary and Uttarakhand in-



Former CM Harish Rawat on Monday said there would be 'no looking back'. ANI

charge Kumari Selja on October 1 wrote to Mr. Rawat, stating he must stop the yatra, which had not been discussed with her or with the State party president, Ganesh Godiyal.

'Strengthening party'

Mr. Rawat's supporters argue that his campaign is aimed at strengthening the party ahead of the poll.

The State leadership and the party brass, however, are concerned about the political message of Mr. Rawat's outreach as the Congress seeks to improve on its recent electoral performance. The Bharatiya Janata Party won 47 of the State's 70 seats in 2022 while the Opposition party won 19.

The former CM is facing probes by Central investigating agencies.

MLC poll: Anant Singh refuses to back party nominee; 3 RLM MLAs float own candidate

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Turmoil within the constituent National Democratic Alliance (NDA) parties appears to be growing ahead of the Bihar Legislative Council election. Senior Janata Dal (United) leader and Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh who was tasked with ending differences between party legislators Anant Singh and Neeraj Kumar, on Monday admitted that he could not persuade Mr. Anant to back Mr. Neeraj, the sitting MLC from the Patna Graduates' seat who has been renominated by the party.

Meanwhile, coalition partner Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) also faced dissent, with three of its four MLAs announcing their own candidate, Ram Pukar Sinha, in the biennial poll instead of the official can-



Mokama MLA Anant Singh of JD(U) has openly supported a JSP candidate. FILE PHOTO

didate – JD(U)'s Anand Pushkar. The last date for filing nominations for the eight seats is October 6. Polling will be held on October 23 and votes will be counted on October 27.

'Misinformation'

Speaking to mediapersons in Patna, Mr. Lalan Singh said, "Today I spoke to Anant Singh. He expressed some reservations, as when he was contesting

the Assembly election from Mokama, as directed by party chief Nitish Kumar, misinformation was spread against him. However, the party did not act against the person despite an appeal by Anant Singh."

The gangster-turned-politician, who went on to win the seat, has accused Mr. Neeraj of spreading canards against him during the 2025 State poll.

"He [Mr. Anant] said he wouldn't support Neeraj. I requested him not to make any statement against the party or the candidate and he agreed," Mr. Lalan said.

Earlier in the day, JD(U) chief and former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and Mr. Lalan Singh held a meeting at the latter's residence in the State capital, reportedly related to Mr. Anant's "rebellion".

The Mokama MLA has made no secret of his in-

tent to ensure Mr. Neeraj's defeat in the October 23 poll. Mr. Anant not only announced his support for the Jan Suraj Party (JSP) candidate, Anuj Kumar, but also took out a procession in support of the Opposition party candidate.

Mr. Neeraj filed his nomination papers on Monday. Addressing reporters later, he said he did not care who was opposing him. "The party has only one centre – Nitish Kumar – and I've got his blessings," said Mr. Neeraj.

The three RLM legislators who announced their decision to go against party president Upendra Kushwaha's direction to support the JD(U) candidate in the Saran Teachers' constituency said they were doing so "out of respect and self-esteem" of party workers. Mr. Kushwaha's wife, Snehlata, is the fourth RLM legislator.

HC nod to DMK defamation suit against TVK IT wing, Ministers

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Monday granted leave (permission) to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) to file a ₹1-crore defamation suit against Ministers Aadhav Arjuna and C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar and the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) Information Technology wing.

The plaintiff, represented by party general secretary Duraimurugan, had filed the suit seeking damages for reportedly accusing the DMK, which was then in power, of having "shielded" child sexual abuse case accused R. Vee-ramani. The plea contended that an FIR had been registered just a day after an activist handed over a video clipping of the alleged sexual assault to the police.

First international cargo vessel leaves Assam since 1947

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

A barge carrying 540 metric tonnes of methanol left the Bogibeel Terminal in Dibrugarh district for Dhaka, Bangladesh, on Monday, marking the first international shipment from eastern Assam since India's independence in 1947.

Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Sarbananda Sonowal, flagged off the vessel *DLB Patkai*, pushed by the tug *Kushal Konwar*, carrying methanol produced by the State-owned Assam Petrochemicals Limited in Namrup.

The vessel, destined for Pangaon port in Dhaka's Narayanganj, will travel about 768 km down the Brahmaputra river (National Waterway-2) to the India-Bangladesh border, and continue along the Indo-Bangladesh Protocol



Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal flagging off the first international cargo vessel from Bogibeel in Dibrugarh district on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Route in the neighbouring country. The total distance is about 1,300 km.

Mr. Sonowal said the cargo shipment is seen as a test of whether the Brahmaputra can serve as a commercially viable freight corridor linking the northeastern region to overseas markets.

"Our grandparents grew up hearing the steamer whistle at Dibrugarh ghat. For 70 years, that whistle

fell silent, and the ships stopped coming. A cargo vessel has left Dibrugarh for the world once again. The river never failed us, but the will to revive the route was lacking for decades," he said.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who attended the flagging-off virtually, said the revival of international cargo movement was a "proud day for Assam".

Inland Waterways Authority of India officials said the shipment became possible after Customs and Immigration complexes were recently set up at Bogibeel and Dhubri.

Busy past

Dibrugarh was once among the busiest river ports in eastern India. Government-run steamers reached the town from Calcutta, now Kolkata, by 1856. In 1882, the Dibrugarh Railway began operating from the Dibrugarh ghat. By 1913, steamers sailed up the Brahmaputra to the town daily, carrying tea, timber and passengers.

The 1947 Partition cut that route, forcing Assam's goods to pass through the then East Pakistan to reach Calcutta. A 1950 earthquake disturbed the riverbed at Dibrugarh, and regular bookings from Di-

brugarh ghat stopped in 1954. The Dibrugarh ghat closed on October 15, 1956, as western ports on the Brahmaputra – Dhubri and Pandu in Guwahati – continued to handle international cargo occasionally.

The 1965 war between India and Pakistan suspended cross-border river trade. India and Bangladesh signed a river trade protocol in 1972. In 1988, the 891 km stretch of the Brahmaputra from Sadiya to Dhubri was declared National Waterway 2. Regular cargo service on the waterway resumed in December 2017, when cement moved from Pandu to Dhubri.

"Every tonne we move on the river means less fuel burnt and fewer trucks on the highway," he said, adding that India is working with Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, and Myanmar on regional waterway links.

Aaditya Thackeray to join protest against MPSC in Pune today; visit by Rahul Gandhi likely this week

Yohan Varghese
MUMBAI

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray will join protesting Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) aspirants in Pune on Tuesday, stepping up the Opposition's support for students demanding the removal of the commission's chairperson, Vivek Bhimanwar, and changes in the recruitment body's functioning.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi is also likely to meet the protesters in Pune this week.

The MPSC has postponed the State Services Main Examination, which was scheduled to be held on October 3.

NCP(SP) MLA Rohit Pa-

war on Monday said the agitation would intensify if the government does not address the students' concerns within 48 hours.

He added, "We have learnt that Rahul Gandhi is likely to come by Wednesday or Thursday. Leaders from Congress's youth wing are also agitating, and they are in contact with his team."

'Spoke to aspirant'

Referring to an aspirant from a farming family in Kolhapur who has become one of the most prominent faces of the stir, Mr. Thackeray wrote on X: "I have just spoken to Vivekanand Patil. Tomorrow, I will go and sit with the students participating in the MPSC agitation in Pune."

He also questioned Mr. Bhimanwar's continuation in office despite "lakhs of students rejecting you and asking you to step aside".

The agitation in Pune has continued for several days, with aspirants raising a range of demands concerning the functioning of the commission.

These include greater transparency in examinations and the removal of its chairperson. Protesters have been gathering at multiple locations in the city.

On September 30, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis met a delegation of MPSC aspirants and announced a series of measures, including the transfer of the MPSC secretary.

(With inputs from PTI)

A.P. assures financial help, jobs to kin of pharma unit blast victims

A.D. Rangarajan
TIRUPATI

Tirupati Collector S. Venkateswar has said that the Andhra Pradesh government would stand by the families of the workers who died in the industrial explosion at a pharmaceutical unit in Sri City on October 3, 2026.

He said the company, TIL Healthcare Private Limited, and the State government would provide assistance to the victims' next of kin.

"This is a deeply painful and irreparable tragedy. To ensure immediate financial relief for the dependents, compensation is being provided to each bereaved family under the Workmen's Compensation Policy, alongside financial support from TIL Healthcare," the Collector said.

Concurrently, the State government had committed to extending complete assistance to rehabilitate the affected families, including securing employment opportunities for eligible family members, the Collector said. He added that the full compensation finalised for the grieving families would be handed out in a couple of days.

Mr. Venkateswar said TIL Healthcare would directly transfer ₹50 lakh to each victim's nominee within two days, while the remaining dues under the Workmen's Compensation Policy will be disbursed at the earliest.

Set up SIT to probe bulk filing of Form 7: Telangana Congress

Party alleges coordinated attempt to remove genuine voters, including Congress leaders, workers, family members; delegation urges Hyderabad Police Commissioner to immediately register FIR

Ravi Reddy
HYDERABAD

The Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) approached Hyderabad Police Commissioner V.C. Sajjanar alleging a coordinated attempt to remove genuine voters, including Congress leaders, workers, their family members and supporters, from electoral rolls through the use of pre-filled Form 7 applications during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR). The party demanded the immediate registration of an FIR and the constitution of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to conduct a comprehensive probe.

A delegation led by



Complaint was made by chairman of TPCC Election Commission Coordination Committee and its members. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

TPCC Election Commission Coordination Committee chairman Pulipati Rajesh Kumar, along with SSA In-charge Gampa Venugopal, DCC presidents Motha Rohit, Deepak John, and Khalid, submitted a detailed complaint alleging that suspicious Form 7 ap-

plications within a span of a few days, indicating a possible organised operation.

‘Organised operation’ According to the complaint, in Musheerabad constituency, a BJP booth-level agent (BLA) allegedly

submitted Form 7 applications seeking the deletion of the names of Congress BLA Sharfuddin and around 31 members of his family. Congress leaders claimed the applications appeared to have been pre-printed or pre-filled, raising serious concerns over their authenticity.

The complaint also cited similar incidents in Bahadurpura and Goshamahal.

Telangana Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), meanwhile, directed District Election Officers (DEO) and Collectors to instruct Electoral Registration Officers (ERO) to take action against applicants who made knowingly false statements or declarations in Forms 6, 6A, 7 and 8.

No inquiry initiated into bulk Form 7 submissions so far, says Karnataka CEO

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Amid multiple cases of Form-7, which is used to file objections and seek deletion of names from the electoral rolls, being filled in bulk, mostly targeting Muslim and minority communities, Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) V. Anbu Kumar said that “in none of the cases has an inquiry been initiated by the Electoral Registration Of-

ficer (ERO)”. Directions have been given to all EROs to take action as per law against those who knowingly make false statements or declarations in writing while filling forms such as Form 7, preceded by an inquiry under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

“So far, no such inquiry has been initiated, and it is left to the ERO to decide when to begin one, if an inquiry is needed. Once it is

initiated, the timeline for a response is seven days,” the CEO said on Monday.

Forms to be ‘examined’ Between June 16 and October 4, 91,278 Form 7 applications have been received by the CEO's office. However, when asked if the figure included bulk Form 7 applications submitted across various constituencies such as Babalshwar, Bhalki and Belagavi, the CEO said, “It

may be included, while some may be rejected. But none of the voters are deleted, and none of the deletions will happen just based on receiving an objection via Form 7. A hearing will be conducted, and only following this will the deletion happen, if need be.”

When questioned if submitting bulk applications was valid, he maintained it needed to be “examined” and depended on the ERO.

UDF convener meets Kharge, airs grievances over Keralam government

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

United Democratic Front convener Adoor Prakash on Monday sought the intervention of the All India Congress Committee (AICC) to address his publicly aired grievances about a lack of consultation in the ruling alliance in Kerala, including “arbitrariness and opaqueness in key decision-making.”

Mr. Prakash held a closed-door meeting with AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge in New Delhi. Emerging from the meeting, Mr. Prakash gave a brief nod to presspersons when asked whether he had brought his criticism, which seemed to obliquely target Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's style of functioning, to the notice of the party's high command. A Congress leader said Mr. Prakash had given a written statement to Mr. Kharge.

HC orders CBI probe into graft allegations against Punjab govt.

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab and Haryana High Court on Monday directed the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to probe corruption allegations linked to Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's office.

The allegations raised by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) against public servants and private individuals linked to the Aam Aadmi party (AAP) government include corruption in transfers and postings, policy manipulation, cash for tenders and other such serious irregularities.

Pronouncing the order on a public interest litigation, a Division Bench of Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and Justice Rohit Kapoor directed the CBI to submit a status report within two months.

The petitioner, advocate Nikhil Saraf, submitted that no action has been taken yet despite



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann

three formal communications sent by the ED to the Punjab police between July 24 and August 12.

The Bench noted that after a cumulative assessment of the material placed on record in the petition, the court is of the considered view that a fair and transparent investigation is required to be carried out in the matter.

Reacting to the development, Minister Aman Arora said the State government will approach the Supreme Court challenging the High Court order.

ODISHA STATE CIVIL SUPPLIES CORPORATION LTD.,
(A Govt. of Odisha Undertaking)
REGISTERED OFFICE : C/2, NAYAPALLI, BHUBANESWAR-751012
CIN: U51211OR1980SGC000894
Tel No: 0674-3544751, **Fax No:** 0674-2395291, **Website:** www.oscsc.in
No.17470 / OSCSC Ltd., Date : 05.10.26

Corrigendum

Ref: Request for Proposal (RFP) Advt. No. 16228/OSCSC Ltd., Date: 17/09/2026
With reference to the RFP issued by OSCSC Ltd. for e-Auction of CMR, the following dates are hereby revised :

Particulars	Existing Date	Revised Date
Last Date of Registration	06.10.2026	12.10.2026
Date of Bidding / e-Auction	08.10.2026 and 09.10.2026	14.10.2026 and 15.10.2026

All other amendments/details of the Corrigendum may be viewed/downloaded from the websites of www.oscsc.in and www.neml.in. All other terms and conditions of the RFP, except those specifically modified through the Corrigendum, shall remain unchanged.
Sd/- Managing Director, OSCSC Ltd.
OIPR-7001/7002/2/26-27/0011

7001/123/2627

Keralam CM's remarks on angioplasty spark a debate

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's remarks at a recent event about avoiding unnecessary angioplasty seems to have stirred a hornets' nest, with many doctors objecting to the “generalised statement”, while some agreed with him.

In a Facebook post, Rajesh Gopalan Nair, Professor and Head of Cardiology at the Government Medical College Hospital, Kozhikode, expressed appreciation for Mr. Satheesan “for pointing out a truth”. This set off an avalanche of comments from doctors and the public, with the latter narrating their harrowing experiences in hospitals, while many doctors expressed disappointment at Dr. Rajesh's stand.

Dr. Rajesh also made it clear in his post that a person coming into the emergency room with a suspected heart attack should not distrust the doctor, for the situation may call for an immediate angioplasty.

On Monday, the Interventional Cardiology Council of Kerala (ICCK) said the public's concerns over “unnecessary” medical procedures should not delay life-saving treatment.

According to ICCK registry data, more than 70% of angioplasties performed in Keralam involved acute and emergency situations.

OFFICE OF THE VICE CHAIRMAN,
JAMMU DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY VIKAS BHAWAN RHC, JAMMU

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS CUM AUCTION
NIT No:-SE/JDA/e-NIT/2026-27/08 dated 03.10.2026
For and on behalf of the Vice Chairman, JDA e-tenders are invited on EPC Mode basis from approved and eligible Contractors / firms registered with J&K Govt., CPWD, Railways and other State/Central Governments for the following work:-

S. No	Name of work	Estimated Cost (Rs. In lacs)	Cost of Tender documents (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (Rs in lacs)	Time of completion	Time & Date of opening of (Technical Bid)
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Construction of RCC Nallah passing through Phase-I Rajinder Nagar, JDA Housing Colony.	Rs. 1996.00	Rs.10000/-	Rs.39.92	12 months	24-10-2026 (1600 hrs onward)

The Bidding documents consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website www.jktenders.gov.in as per below schedule:

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	03-10-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 03-10-2026, 1600 hrs to 23-10-2026 1400 hrs
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	15-10-2026 (1400 hrs) in the Office of Superintending Engineer JDA Vikas Bhawan RHC, Jammu
4	Bid Submission Start Date	03-10-2026 1600 hrs
5	Bid Submission End Date	23-10-2026 upto 1400 hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	24-10-2026 1600 hrs onward in the Office of Superintending Engineer JDA Vikas Bhawan RHC, Jammu.
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	Shall be notified to the responsive bidders
8	Reverse Auction	Shall be notified to the responsive bidders

Sd/-
Superintendent Engineer
Jammu Development Authority
Jammu
DIP/J-2440-P/26 Oct 5 2026

देवी अहिल्या विश्वविद्यालय, इंदौर
विश्वविद्यालय भवन, इंदौर-452001
क्रमांक/परीक्षा/उत्तरपुस्तिकाएं क्रय/ई-निविदा/2026/ दिनांक : 05.10.2026

ऑनलाइन ई-निविदा आमंत्रण

देवी अहिल्या विश्वविद्यालय, इंदौर द्वारा mptender के माध्यम से कोरी उत्तरपुस्तिकाएं क्रय करने हेतु, ई-निविदा क्रमांक परीक्षा/ई-निविदा/2026/1622 आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण देवी अहिल्या विश्वविद्यालय, इंदौर की वेबसाइट www.dauniv.ac.in पर भी देखा जा सकता है।
म.प्र., माध्यम/128368/2026

Jammu and Kashmir Bank
Central Stationary Department,
Nowgam, Bypass
Srinagar 190015 J&K

On-Line RFP (e-RFP) for Printing & Supply of Printed Stationery Items

RFP Notice along with Complete RFP document outlining the minimum requirements can be downloaded from and Bids can be submitted on the Banks' e-Tendering Portal <https://jkbank.abcpocure.com> w.e.f. October 03, 2026, 16.00 Hrs. RFP Document can also be downloaded from Bank's Official Website <https://jkbank.in/> Last date for submission of Bids is October 27, 2026, 17.00 Hrs.
e-RFP Ref. No.: JKB/CHQ/CSD/Printed-Stationery/2026-1915
Dated : 03-10-2026
Registered office : Corporate Headquarters, M.A.Road, Srinagar 190001, Kashmir, India
CIN: L6510KJ1985GSC000048 ; **T :** +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 ; **F :** +91 (0)194 248 1928; **E :** info@jkbank.com ; **W :** <https://Jkb.bank.in>

Government of Himachal Pradesh
Public Works Department

e-Procurement Notice
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Executive Engineer, Kullu Division HP, PWD, Kullu on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh invites bids on **percentage rates**, in electronic tendering system, in 2 cover System for the under mentioned work from the eligible and approved contractors/Firm registered with HP,PWD, department.

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Name of Division	Estimated cost of the Work	Bid Security / of EMD	Cost of Docu-ment	Period of Compl-ement
1.	Balance work of restoration of rain damages on Jia Manikaran road Km. 1/610 to 35/110 (Job No. No.CRF-HP-2023-24/188) (S.H.-Construction of F/C R/wall, M/T, V-shape drain, U-shape drain ,Hume pipe culvert and Chevron Markers).	E.E. Kullu Division	2,26,08,256/-	4,52,000/-	7,000/-	Six months
2.	Starting date of downloading Bid.					12.10.2026
3.	Deadline for submission of Bid.					21.10.2026
4.	Date of opening of Bid					22.10.2026, 10.30 AM

Bidders documents can be downloaded from the website <http://hptenders.gov.in>. The documents downloaded from the site should not be tempered, and if any such tempering is detected before or after the opening of bids, the bidder shall be penalized and black listed.

Other terms and condition shall remain same as given in CPWD Manual 2019 and as per the bid document.

Terms & Conditions:-
1. **Scanned copy of Registration/Enlistment with H.P.P.W.D. Deptt.**
2. **Scanned copy of PAN/TIN & Income Tax clearance certificate.**
3. **Scanned copy of work done certificate of similar nature of work and authentication of ownership of machinery which is required as paver, Hot mix plant, Excavator/, DE-watering pumps, Capacity and Air Compressor etc.**
4. **Scanned copy of Earnest Money and Cost of Form.**
5. **Scanned copy of Affidavit regarding genuineness and correctness of document attached.**
6. **The rates beyond over +5% will be rejected, besides this the Additional Performance security will have to borne @ 20% & 30% for unbalanced bid in case rates is lower than 10% but upto 20% & lower than 20% upto 30% respectively. The tender beyond the limit of -30% will also be accepted.**
Executive Engineer,
Kullu Division, HP,PWD,Kullu.
For and on behalf of the Governor of H.P.

HP / 3892/26-27

MUMBAI PORT AUTHORITY
मुंबई पत्तन प्राधिकरण

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

RFP No. CET - 77/2026 | GLOBAL INVITATION | PPP - DBFOT
Mumbai Port Authority under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Govt. of India, invites online proposals from eligible Indian / international developers / joint ventures for
Development of World-Class Full-Service Viksit Bharat Mumbai Marina and Integrated Waterfront Assets, Mumbai on Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) basis.

• Marina terminal, Marina club, sailing school, dry stack and repair yard.
• Supporting infrastructure: 5-Star Hotel and Tourism Business Centre.
• Total Permissible Built-up Area – 1,06,000 sqm.

Opposite the Domestic Cruise Terminal, with access via the Eastern Freeway and Atal Setu.

Bid documents available from	Pre-bid meeting	Last date for bid submission
12.10.2026	27.10.2026	25.11.2026

Chief Engineer, MbPA, Port House, Shoorji Vallabhdas Marg, Ballard Estate, Mumbai – 400 001 |
Email: chiefengineer@mumbaiport.gov.in | **Tel:** 022-6656 4031

Corrigenda / addenda, if any, will be published only on the above websites and not in newspapers.

Tablets (India) Limited

PUBLIC NOTICE

Tablets (India) Limited clarifies that it has No Factories in Sri City; TIL Healthcare Private Limited and Tablets (India) Limited are two independent entities.

Tablets (India) Limited categorically clarifies that it is not connected with the incident involving the industrial boiler blast reported at TIL Healthcare Private Limited, Sri City.

We would like to place the facts on record that Tablets (India) Limited has no factory or manufacturing facility in Sri City, Andhra Pradesh. It is further clarified that Tablets (India) Limited and TIL Healthcare Private Limited are two completely different and independent entities, with no common ownership & management between them.

We convey our deepest condolences to the bereaved families. We request the media and the public to take note of the distinction between the two companies to avoid any further confusion.

This clarification is being issued to correct the record, prevent any misunderstanding and ensure that the facts are accurately communicated to readers and the public.

Executive Engineer,
Kullu Division, HP,PWD,Kullu.
For and on behalf of the Governor of H.P.

GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB

TENDER NOTICE

SR. NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK/ NOTICE/ TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT/ EMD (AP-PROX.) IN LACS	NODAL OFFICER / CONTACT / EMAIL
1.	Principal Resident Commissioner, Punjab Bhawan, New Delhi	Supply of Egg and Bread (Harvest or Britannia)	06/10/2026 21/10/2026	10.00 Thousand	9871155820 punjabbhawan@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION AND CORRIGENDUM & ADDENDUM IF ANY, KINDLY VISIT: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in/>, www.punjab.gov.in

RO Number: 1001/12/202 6-27/15873

TAMIL NADU STATE MARKETING CORPORATION LIMITED
CMDA TOWER- II, IV FLOOR, GANDHIRIRWIN BRIDGE ROAD, EGMORE, CHENNAI-600 008.
Phone: 044-28521970, 044-28524589 | E-mail: tasmac.mse@tasmac.com

e-Tender
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation Ltd (TASMAC) invites online tenders/bids in two cover system (Cover-I-Technical Bid and Cover-II-Financial Bid) for Empanelment of Internal Auditors for District Manager Offices and Retail Vending shops under its control for the period October 2026 –March 2027 and extendable for 2 financial years April 2027 to March 2028 and April 2028 to March 2029

TAMIL NADU STATE MARKETING CORPORATION LIMITED
CMDA TOWER- II, IV FLOOR, GANDHIRIRWIN BRIDGE ROAD, EGMORE, CHENNAI-600 008.
Phone: 044-28521970, 044-28524589 **NOTICE INVITING TENDER**
(For publishing in the Website)
Tender Reference No. TASHO/2341/2026-T-1

Tender forms available at <https://tenders.gov.in/nicgepp/app>

Bid validity The Bid remain valid for a period of not less than 120 days from the last date of submission of the bid.

Place of opening of technical bid TASMAC, Corporate Office, Egmore, Chennai-8.

Sl. No.	Activity	Schedule
1	Commencement of download of the Tender Document	05.10.2026 at 6.30 PM
2	Pre-Bid Meeting	09.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M
3	Seek Clarification Start Date	09.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M
4	Seek Clarification End Date	12.10.2026 at 04.00 P.M
5	Bid submission start date	09.10.2026 at 5.00 P.M
6	Last date and time for submission of Bids	20.10.2026 at 06.30 P.M
7	Opening of Technical Bids	21.10.2026 at 10.00 A.M
8	Opening of Financial Bids	To be communicated to the qualified bidders

1. The tender document can be downloaded from the portal <https://tenders.gov.in/nicgepp/app>.
2. Tenderers are advised to follow the instructions provided in the Tender document for the e-submission of the bids through online e-procurement system of Government of Tamil Nadu website, <https://tenders.gov.in>
Note: If any of the dates mentioned above is declared as Government Holiday or unplanned shutdown by the State, the due date will be postponed to the next working day at the same scheduled time. To enable TASMAC to meet the target dates, bidders are expected to respond promptly to any clarifications requested during the evaluation process. TASMAC will adhere to the above schedule to the best of its ability, but reserves the right to modify it. Notification of any changes will be provided to all bidders.

DIPR/3028/TEIN/2026

MANAGING DIRECTOR

HP / 3892/26-27

A ND-NDE



Good, not good enough

Without raising sports standards, India should not bid for hosting the Olympics

Aspiring to host the Olympic Games in 2036, India faced a harsh reality check at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games. Compared with the previous Hangzhou Games, where it won 106 medals with a 650-plus contingent, the country won 85 medals from around 500 athletes. The aggregate fell short of an internally projected figure of around 100 medals. It is likely to invite a thorough postmortem, given the hundreds of crores of public money spent on the athletes' preparation. India laboured to 21 gold medals, seven fewer than in Hangzhou, after a late surge of 11 top honours in the last two days, driven by the exploits of archers, boxers, wrestlers, and hockey and cricket players. It tied with Uzbekistan but managed to retain its fourth spot on the strength of a bigger haul of silver. Thirteen of the gold medals came from team events, with cricket, kabaddi and hockey making a clean sweep of titles. It underscored a stark reality: the country needs to raise its bar in medal-fetching individual sports, such as athletics, swimming, gymnastics, fencing and cycling, which determine success in multi-disciplinary Games. China, the runaway winner with a massive aggregate of 341 medals, including 169 gold, secured 54 medals in swimming alone. Barring athletics, India stood nowhere.

On a brighter note, India fielded 310 debutants and recorded a marginal increase in its athlete-to-medal ratio ahead of Los Angeles 2028. Several historic performances provided reasons to rejoice. Seventeen-year-old rookie recurve archer Kumkum Mohod dismantling the Korean women's hegemony to help the archery team contribute five gold medals was a defining moment. Trap shooter Neeru Dhandu, golfer Pranavi Urs, wrestler Sujeet Kalkal and the women's hockey team, which upset Paris Olympics silver medallist China to clinch gold after 44 years, hogged the limelight. Lovlina Borgohain, Aman Sehrawat, Mirabai Chhanu, Vithya Ramraj and Gulveer Singh lived up to their billing. Boxers, wrestlers and golfers registered noticeable improvement. Olympic quota places in archery and hockey added to the excitement. Indian women catching up with men – both genders delivered 38 medals apiece – was another encouraging sign. On the flip side, India's two major contributors, athletics and shooting, which earned 24 and 15 medals, respectively, yielded 12 fewer medals than in 2023. The shuttlers slipped, while the tennis players returned empty-handed after 40 years. P.V. Sindhu and Manu Bhaker flopped. Stricter scrutiny of athletes' funding and efficient implementation of the revamped Khelo India scheme, designed with a long-term vision, are essential for course correction. Without propelling India's sporting standards, a bid to host the Olympics may become a countdown to international embarrassment.

Bird islands

India's conservation efforts must go beyond symbolism

This week, at the Desert National Park in Jaisalmer, two male Great Indian Bustards were released into the wild. It was a ceremony with considerable bureaucratic pomp; the Union and the Rajasthan Environment Ministers were in attendance. The conservation plan now has 97 birds, with nine more awaiting release. Of these, 57 are captive-bred and have produced 29 chicks this year and 24 last year. These are notable numbers for a species with a population of around 120 that has teetered on the brink of extinction for nearly half a century. It is worth recounting the bird's conservation travails. Ornithologist Salim Ali wanted it as the national bird, so that protection would follow; the Indian Board for Wildlife chose the peacock instead. Numbering about 1,260 in 1969, it dipped to 600 by 2000, and 140-175 in Rajasthan by the 2010s. Hunters, royal ones included, prized the bird, with shooting reportedly lasting into the late 1970s. The rise of irrigation in Rajasthan led to the grasslands, which were once dismissed as 'wastelands', give way to irrigated, pesticide-soaked fields and roads making the bird more vulnerable. The most recent threat came in the form of high-tension power lines. As a heavy bird, the bustard tends to fly at the same height as power lines and has poor vision. The Supreme Court in 2021 ordered that low-voltage lines in priority habitats be underground. After opprobrium from renewable energy companies, on the grounds that this compromised the economics of solar power, the Court modified the order requiring that only a subset of the power lines – those part of the bird's 'critical' habitat – be made underground.

While the cultural links of the 'Godawan' - the bird's local name - to Rajasthan's habitat are now part of government and private marketing efforts, there are several other birds that are not as fortunate. Nearly 1,256 bird species, about 11.5% of the world's total, are classified as threatened. Skylark numbers have fallen nearly 80% and Indian rollers 30% in 12 years. India's conservation policy is captive to symbolism. A tigress from Valmiki flown to Buxa; African cheetahs in enclosures; Gir's lions, confined to Saurashtra and straying in to human habitations stoking conflict; the Delhi Ridge, being planted with peepal and banyan that ecologists say do not belong to its dry ecology. The conservation ethos – on paper emphasising coexistence between the wild and human – is practically promoting islands and African-style reserves. These have merits but populations that thrive inside walls overflow into villages and fields, as India's challenges with elephants show. Landscapes, not species, ought to be the unit of conservation.

A recent World Bank forecast reveals that the global economy stands at the precipice of a silent catastrophe. A recent warning issued by Bank President Ajay Banga is stark: over the coming decade, an astonishing 1.2 billion young men and women in the Global South will reach working age, but the global economy is projected to generate no more than 400 million viable jobs. This creates a staggering deficit of 800 million opportunities in the job market, a demographic chasm of such unprecedented magnitude that it threatens to convert what should be the greatest economic dividend of the 21st century into a catalyst for widespread instability.

A failing blueprint

For decades, economic theorists have championed the demographic dividend as the primary engine for lifting developing nations out of poverty. The formula appeared straightforward: as fertility rates decline, the proportion of working-age adults relative to dependents increases, creating a temporary window of high productivity, elevated domestic savings, and rapid capital accumulation that fuelled the East Asian economic miracle in the late 20th century. Today, however, that classic blueprint is failing. Developing nations such as India are experiencing their youth bulges at a historical moment when the traditional escalators of economic mobility are stalling. The sheer velocity of demographic growth in many countries is outstripping the rate at which domestic markets, infrastructure, and institutional frameworks can absorb new labour, turning the potential dividend into a looming crisis.

Central to the dilemma is the rapid evolution of global trade, technology, and manufacturing. Historically, light manufacturing served as the indispensable bridge for low-income nations transitioning away from subsistence agriculture, absorbing millions of unskilled and semi-skilled workers into productive urban employment. Today, automation, robotics, and advanced industrial software have drastically reduced the labour intensity of manufacturing. As a result, developing nations are experiencing premature deindustrialisation: their manufacturing sectors are losing jobs before reaching the income thresholds of industrial economies of the past. Furthermore, the modern global economy increasingly rewards high-skilled, technology-driven labour, widening the chasm for millions of youth in developing countries who lack access to modern digital infrastructure, quality vocational training, or tertiary education.

There is no easy solution. The World Bank recommends unlocking private sector capital and



Shashi Tharoor

Four-term Member of Parliament (Congress) for Thiruvananthapuram, who served nearly three decades at the United Nations, where he rose to the position of Under-Secretary-General. He has also been Minister of State for External Affairs and for Human Resource Development in the Government of India and is the bestselling author, among others, of 'Pax Indica: India and the World of the 21st century'

dismantling the regulatory sclerosis that throttles domestic enterprise in many developing economies. Potential entrepreneurs face prohibitive costs of capital, erratic regulatory environments and predatory taxation. Complex legal frameworks and weak property rights scare away long-term foreign direct investment, confining capital to speculative assets rather than employment-generating ventures. Simplifying regulatory regimes, establishing transparent governance structures, and bolstering institutional integrity are essential preconditions for creating environments where small and medium-sized enterprises, the main engines of global job creation, can launch, grow, and hire.

India lags here, but does better in improving infrastructure, another key recommendation. A small business cannot compete in global supply chains, nor can it grow locally, if it suffers from routine power failures or exorbitant logistics costs caused by dilapidated roads and port congestion. Modernising physical and digital infrastructure serves a dual economic purpose: the construction and deployment phase itself absorbs massive quantities of immediate labour, while the resulting assets lower the cost of doing business across the economy.

Sector-specific strategies are ideal

Within this broader macroeconomic overhaul, targeted sector-specific strategies offer the most realistic pathway toward mass labour absorption. Agriculture still remains the largest employer in the developing world. Transitioning from low-yield subsistence farming to high-value, technology-enabled agri-tech and commercial agribusiness can transform rural economies. By investing in cold-chain logistics, localised food processing, and climate-resilient farming techniques, nations can create sophisticated rural value chains that offer meaningful, remunerative employment to young people, reducing the desperate tide of distress migration to the cities.

Health care and the broader care economy offer other possibilities for employment expansion. The demand for trained health-care workers, nurses, community health personnel, and elder-care specialists is exploding. Investing in health human resources delivers a powerful double dividend: it creates millions of resilient, non-outsourcable domestic jobs (predominantly for young women who are often excluded from formal labour markets) while simultaneously building the human capital necessary to sustain long-term national productivity.

Similarly, tourism and culture offer an extraordinary vehicle for decentralised job creation. Tourism is inherently labour-intensive, engages semi-skilled and unskilled workers and is resistant to total automation. It possesses a

A widening jobs gap threatens the promise of demographic dividends; the Global South faces an unprecedented employment challenge

America's new-age military populism takes shape



Harsh V. Pant

Vice President, Observer Research Foundation (ORF), New Delhi



Vivek Mishra

Deputy Director, Strategic Studies Programme at the Observer Research Foundation

America's military transformation under the Trump administration combines technological reform with the politics of populism

to place technological superiority *vis-à-vis* China front and centre. Among the other steps announced to overhaul the U.S. military is the "Fortress America" project, intended to redesign energy and cyber connectivity so that U.S. bases become self-sufficient in both electricity grids and cyber command. Towards realigning the recruitment system, the Pentagon will now work with five select universities to establish a new corps of cadets. The absence of any Ivy League institution is telling of the Trump administration's long war against elite educational institutions and the values that new-age Republicans associate with them.

Perhaps the most consequential move was Mr. Hegseth's announcement of a 20% cut in general and flag officer positions across the armed forces by January 1, 2027 – double the reduction he announced in 2025. Mr. Hegseth's broad definition of "redundant force structure", which he has used as a pretext to trim the military's senior ranks, now also extends to ending new tenured appointments of civilian academics at military service academies. Besides these measures, the decision to establish an Office of Religious Affairs (ORA), reporting directly to the Secretary of War and providing religious support and spiritual readiness, bears all the hallmarks of Republican evangelical outreach writ large.

Drivers behind the overhaul

Behind the overhaul of the DoW lies a convergence of competing drivers: populism, rapid technological evolution, cultural revivalism, assessments of comparative military might and capability, and a race against time. Americans view the changes differently on each metric. For instance, while most see the decision to set up the Autonomous Warfare Command as a necessity, the removal of senior military ranks has drawn flak – as a decapitation of the military leadership from within. The departure of the Army Secretary, Dan Driscoll, in August was the culmination of the urge to purge that Mr. Hegseth has evinced.

Mr. Hegseth's measures, taken together, offer a decidedly mixed picture. The U.S. is approaching the end of a military era that began with the Reagan administration's sweeping military-industrial transformation in the

uniquely broad multiplier effect, driving revenues down to local transport providers, hospitality workers, artisans, and historical preservation efforts. Strategic investments in sustainable tourism infrastructure and international destination marketing translates directly into widespread employment.

Manufacturing, too, must be reimagined. Modern light assembly, green-transition manufacturing (such as the production of solar components, electric two-wheelers, and energy-efficient materials) and decentralised production networks can still absorb substantial labour if paired with agile skill-building programmes.

History demonstrates that when vast cohorts of educated, energetic, and ambitious young people are denied access to productive economic life, the resulting frustration erodes trust in governments, fuels social polarisation, and creates fertile ground for extremist or criminal ideologies and civil unrest. In an interconnected world, failure to generate livelihoods in the Global South will inevitably accelerate forced migration flows toward the Global North, exacerbating political tensions worldwide.

Preventing prolonged youth unemployment from leading to global catastrophe requires an unprecedented alignment of international finance, domestic political courage, and private sector dynamism. Developed economies and multilateral financial institutions must facilitate affordable, long-term development financing and technology transfers, while developing nations must undertake the hard, often politically painful work of institutional reform. The global economy possesses the financial resources and technological tools required to meet this challenge. But can the international community muster the collective resolve to build an inclusive global order where every young person is afforded a fair opportunity to work, contribute, and thrive? In today's climate this writer would not count on it.

As the world's most populous nation, India sits at the epicentre of this dynamic, adding millions of young entrants to its workforce each year while grappling with an economy that has struggled to match GDP growth with employment creation. The nation's immediate challenge, in a dwindling demographic window, includes matching skills to markets, persistent underemployment, low female labour force participation, and an agrarian sector that still absorbs nearly half the population despite producing just 16% of GDP (FY24). India, with a median age under 30, must move toward labour-absorbing value creation. Otherwise its celebrated demographic dividend could collapse into a demographic disaster.

Reform and strategic necessity

The problem is that the Trump administration's sense of urgency has too often conflated the politics of populism with the imperatives of military reform. In the process, the distinction between political messaging and strategic necessity-and, at times, between friend and foe-has become blurred.

Mr. Hegseth's rhetoric about creating forces with "no fannies, no trannies, no beards, no weirdos", alongside his proposal for mandatory testosterone-deficiency testing in the annual health screenings of personnel aged 30 years and above, takes the notion of a "warrior ethos" into territory that appears increasingly disconnected from the demands of modern warfare. At a time when technological superiority, automation, artificial intelligence and precision systems are reshaping the character of conflict, military effectiveness cannot be reduced to an increasingly narrow conception of physical warriorhood.

Yet, it would be a mistake to allow the excesses of this rhetoric to obscure the genuine opportunities before the U.S.. President Trump's two terms have coincided with an extraordinary acceleration in technological change, creating both significant challenges and important possibilities for American military power. The re-establishment of the Space Command in 2019 was one such consequential step, while the more recent announcement of AutoWarCom could, if pursued seriously, have transformative implications for the organisation and the deployment of military power.

The larger task is to ensure that such initiatives are driven by the requirements of future warfare rather than subsumed by the vocabulary of populism. For the world's most powerful military, the stakes are ultimately too high for political theatre to substitute for strategic clarity.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Push Russia towards peace

It is disquieting that inspite of appeals, proddings including warnings by a raft of global leaders and organisations, there is no indication on the part of the Russian President Vladimir

Putin to halt the hostilities against Ukraine that have entered the fifth year. (Inside pages, October 4). The relentless aerial attacks by Russia have caused colossal destruction. Before the situation spins out of

control, it is incumbent upon the key countries which profess supremacy in warfare to step up various forms of pressure on Russia to end the war.

V. Johan Dhanakumar, Chennai

Singeetham Srinivasa Rao

In the passing of Singeetham Srinivasa Rao, Indian cinema has lost a legendary director who envisioned concepts far ahead of his time. With extraordinary command of

various crafts, he created unique and pathbreaking films. His landmark projects inspired a generation of film-makers. Indian cinema has also lost a celluloid innovator who explored

almost every genre with limited resources.

Satish Reddy Kanaganti, Tipparrhi, Nalgonda, Telangana

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Disabled citizens and the future of AI

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Decline in India's sunflower oil imports in September

36 in per cent, Indian sunflower oil imports fell in September to their lowest level in more than four years after the Ukraine war disrupted shipments. India's sunflower oil imports plunged 36% from a month earlier to 103,000 metric tonnes in September, dealers' average estimates showed. PTI

Years after which Odisha is holding student union polls

8 Students' union elections will be held in public colleges and universities across Odisha on October 15, ending an eight-year hiatus, Higher Education Minister Suryabanshi Suraj said on Monday. "The election is aimed at preparing the leadership for the future from the college level," he said. PTI

High schools disrupted due to French student protests

413 France high school students protest disrupted lessons at 413 of the country's 3,700 schools on Monday, the Education Ministry said, down from the number of schools affected last week. It said the drop was due to "sustained dialogue with high school students". AFP

Death toll from flooding in Thailand since mid-September

31 Thai authorities on Monday warned of more rain and flash flooding as the death toll from floods across the country since mid-September rose to 31. Thunderstorms, strong winds and heavy rain are expected across much of upper Thailand from Monday through Wednesday. AP

Spain's crude oil imports from January and August

2.32 million metric tonnes. Between January and August, Spain imported 2.32 million metric tonnes of crude from Venezuela, the highest for this period since the 2.39 million tonnes imported in 2006, according to data. REUTERS
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why is Buxa bringing tigers back?

Why was Buxa chosen for reintroduction? How will the tigers be reintroduced? Why was Valmiki chosen as the source? What are the challenges? Can Buxa sustain a tiger population? How has tiger reintroduction worked in India? Why did tigers disappear from Buxa? How will the reintroduced tigers be monitored?

EXPLAINER

Shiv Sahay Singh

The story so far:

In October 2, a three-year-old tigress, T138, was released in Buxa Tiger Reserve in West Bengal, marking the beginning of a phased programme to reintroduce tigers and establish a viable, self-sustaining population in the reserve. Three more tigers are likely to be introduced to the reserve, which has not recorded much presence of tigers over the past few years.

The tigress was translocated from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve and released in the presence of Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav and West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenhu Adhikari.

Initially, the tigress would be kept in an enclosed area of about 2.3 hectares to allow the animal to acclimatise to its new surroundings before it is released into the wider reserve. T138 would be subject to intensive post-release monitoring using a combination of telemetry, camera trapping and field-based monitoring to assess her movement, adaptation, health and behaviour.

The release of the tigress is not merely about bringing tigers back to Buxa, but its "objective is to create the conditions in which a tiger population can establish, breed and ultimately become viable and self-sustaining," PIB said in a statement.

Why is Buxa Tiger Reserve significant?

Buxa was declared a tiger reserve in 1983 and is the 15 th tiger reserve in the country. Buxa Tiger Reserve is situated in the Alipurduar Sub-division of Jalpaiguri District, West Bengal.

With an area of 760.87 sq. km, the reserve stretches over a length of 50 km from west to east and 35 km from north to south. The reserve has corridor connectivity across the border with the



Three-year-old tigress, T138, walks through the forest after being released into the wild at Buxa Tiger Reserve, in Alipurduar, West Bengal. PTI

forests of Bhutan in the north; to the east, it has linkages with the Kochugaon forests, Manas Tiger Reserve, and to the West with the Jaldapara National Park.

One of the reasons for low tiger density has been changes in the habitat due to increasing anthropogenic pressure. "Over the decades, however, habitat degradation and fragmentation, changes in land use and decline in prey availability have affected the ecological conditions required to sustain a resident tiger population. The Reserve subsequently witnessed a prolonged absence of a stable resident tiger population," a PIB statement said.

Why was Valmiki Tiger Reserve selected for bringing the tigress?

The National Tiger Conservation Authority found that there were no tigers at Buxa, Dampa and Palamu tiger reserves; it initiated a programme of reintroduction of tigers in 2018, which has resulted in the reintroduction of tigers at Buxa. Scientists and forest officials were looking for a habitat similar to Buxa from which the tiger may be brought to the reserve. Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve, which lies in the easternmost part of the Terai Arc Landscape, was considered suitable for tiger augmentation because of the similarities in terrain with Buxa.

West Bengal has a thriving tiger population in the Sundarbans, the only mangrove forest in the world to have tigers. As per the last census, the Indian Sundarbans is home to about 100 tigers in the unique mangrove ecosystem. However, translocating tigers from the Sundarbans to Buxa may not have worked because of the vast differences in the terrain and the habitat.

What has been the experience with reintroduction of tigers?

Tiger 'reintroduction' done in India is the first such scientific endeavour in the world, says NTCA. Reintroducing tigers in the Indian context means establishing a tiger population in an area which was part of its historical range but from where it has gone locally extinct.

The tiger reintroduction has been a successful collaborative venture between the NTCA, State governments, and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), with numbers of tigers increasing in reserves where the exercise was carried out.

The reintroduction started in 2008 when tigers were successfully reintroduced in Sariska (Rajasthan) and Panna (Madhya Pradesh) Tiger Reserves. The tiger reintroduction programme has been carried out across 12 tiger reserves in less than two decades.

The success of the programme, however, has not been uniform across the reserves.

A publication titled "Reintroduction & Population Recovery of Tigers in India: Field Experiences & Key Learnings" released by NTCA and WII earlier this year has pointed out that relocation of tigers in Satkosia Tiger Reserve posed several challenges. "The translocated tigers encountered difficulties in adapting to the new environment, and the landscape experienced considerable human-tiger conflict, including incidents of livestock depredation and negative local responses," the report said.

The NTCA website also added that in the past there have been few examples of tiger 'release' (Dongarpur in Rajasthan and in Russia) which were not successful owing to several factors.

Keeping these challenges in mind, the NTCA has prepared a protocol on tiger re-introduction. The protocol deals with aims and objectives of reintroduction, constitution of team, pre-project activities, conducting feasibility study, selection and evaluation of site, suitability of release stock of tigers, socio-economic requirements, preparation for release and post-release activities.

What are the challenges?

Buxa Tiger Reserve had not had a resident tiger for several years, though on some occasions tigers have been recorded in the winter months.

The reserve is dotted with settlements and surrounded by revenue villages and tea estates. The State government has convinced about 300 families to relocate so that they can make the tiger reintroduction exercise successful. Wildlife, particularly elephants, has been threatened by linear infrastructure including a railway line, resulting in the deaths of hundreds of pachyderms over the decade. Because the region lies close to Bhutan, heavy commercial traffic on the road connecting Bhutan and West Bengal through Buxa poses an additional concern.

THE GIST

▼ A three-year-old tigress from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve has been released in Buxa Tiger Reserve as part of a phased programme to establish a viable, self-sustaining tiger population

▼ Valmiki was chosen because its terrain is similar to Buxa, while translocation from the Sundarbans was considered unsuitable due to differences in habitat and terrain

▼ The reintroduction faces challenges including habitat degradation, low prey availability, human settlements, linear infrastructure and heavy commercial traffic through the reserve

Why are States divided over the mining amendment?

Amendment curbs States' fiscal powers, but their responses vary with dependence and political alignment

Safira Hussain
Sanjay Kumar

In a federal country like India, differences between the Centre and the States over certain issues are not unusual. One such instance recently arose over the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, passed by Parliament.

Under the amended Act, the Centre's regulatory powers over mining have been expanded to cover not only mines and mineral development but also mineral-bearing lands. It bars States from imposing fresh taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands, except under conditions prescribed by the Union government. It also cancels mineral taxes imposed by States but not fully collected before the Act came into force.

Mines and minerals are a subject over which legislative powers are divided between the Centre and the States. State governments are empowered to regulate

mines and minerals under entry 23 of the State List, but this power is subject to central legislation as per entry 54 of the Union List. The latter entry gives Parliament the discretion to determine the extent of authority over mining regulation and development in the public interest. The Constitution also gives States powers to tax mineral rights and land through entries 50 and 49 of the State List. The recent amendment draws on the Centre's regulatory authority over mineral development to place new limits on these State-level taxing powers. So, the issue widens from mining regulation to the fiscal autonomy of mineral-rich States.

The amended provisions contradict the constitutional provision articulated by the Supreme Court in 2024. The court held that States can tax mineral rights, subject to Parliament's power to limit this in the public interest, while their power to tax mineral-bearing land cannot be curtailed through Parliament's powers under Entry 54. The Centre has argued that uneven and multiple State-level taxes raise the

cost of domestic minerals, prompting industries to turn to imports and placing an additional burden on the exchequer. By invalidating unrecovered past dues, the law hits at the potential source of revenue for States, narrowing the prospective mineral-related revenue for some of the major mineral-bearing States.

The fiscal stakes

Mineral-related receipts account for 85% of non-tax revenue in Jharkhand and 80% in Odisha, compared with 48% in Karnataka, 41% in Madhya Pradesh and 39% in Rajasthan. Telangana and Chhattisgarh are less dependent, with mineral receipts making up 11% and 6%, respectively. For Jharkhand and Odisha, restrictions on the ability to impose or retain mineral-related levies therefore have significant fiscal implications, while the immediate impact may be smaller in Telangana and Chhattisgarh. Odisha is particularly revealing in this regard. Despite deriving a substantial share of its non-tax revenue from minerals, the State

has not responded with a unified position. The Opposition has demanded a special Assembly session. The BJP-led State government, however, has rejected the demand and argued that the amendment would not harm Odisha's mineral revenues. Telangana, where mineral receipts account for only about 11% of non-tax revenue, has also joined other non-NDA-ruled States intending to move the Supreme Court against the amendment. While Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh and Kerala are planning to challenge the law in the Supreme Court, arguing that the restrictions on State taxation of mineral rights and mineral-bearing land undermine States' fiscal powers and federalism, Kerala has additionally argued that treating mineral-bearing land in this manner gives the Centre wider powers over areas such as the State's coastal and forest regions. Jharkhand has also raised objections, with the Chief Minister warning that the loss of revenue from mineral taxes could affect social-security schemes benefiting millions because the amended Act renders certain uncollected past dues invalid. By contrast, there has been no comparable challenge from States such as Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan or Chhattisgarh so far.

The political geography of this discontent points to an interesting feature of Indian federalism. Even when the underlying concern is perceived erosion of States' fiscal space, the extent to which it becomes a federal issue varies across States. Mineral dependence creates a

material stake, while political alignment may influence whether that stake translates into an organised federal challenge.

India's fiscal federal structure comes across as asymmetric rather than purely decentralised. It gives greater taxation powers to the Centre while placing greater expenditure responsibilities on the States in several areas. The Centre has significant influence over borrowing and transfers to the States, which restricts State autonomy when they depend on the Centre's transfers or require its approval for borrowing. How much fiscal autonomy do States possess, and how far can the Union influence it often becomes a bone of contention between them.

The evolving Indian federal dynamic is marked by push and pull between the central authority and States' autonomy. Conflicts between the Centre and the States over legislative jurisdiction, fiscal resources, administrative control, and even foreign policy engagements have surfaced time and again, be it over the GST compensation, the terms of reference for Finance Commissions, the National Education Policy, the Citizenship Amendment Act, and proposed amendments to All-India Services rules, to list a few. This amendment therefore adds another fault line to India's continuing Centre-State contest over legislative authority and fiscal autonomy. (Safira Hussain is currently associated with Lokniti-CSDS; Sanjay Kumar is a Professor and an election analyst)

ABSTRACT



Physicist and Nobel laureate
Werner Heisenberg. GETTY IMAGES

The Nazi nuke: Werner Heisenberg was more off target than he believed

Using nuclear archaeology, scientists have found that the Nobel laureate may have grossly overestimated his team's ability to build a nuclear weapon by 1945; they found that Germany lacked the uranium, heavy water, and reactor-grade graphite needed to achieve a sustained chain reaction

Vasudevan Mukunth

Patrick J. Park, Brittany Robertson, Miriam E. Hiebert, Jason Zhao, Ciara B. Sivels and Timothy W. Koeth, 'Nuclear archaeology reassesses Heisenberg's last reactor experiment', PNAS Nexus, Vol. 5, Issue No. 9, September 29, 2026

Hans Bethe. Felix Bloch. Niels Bohr. Albert Einstein. Enrico Fermi. James Franck. Otto Frisch. Samuel Goudsmit. Lilli Hornig. Rolf Landshoff. Maria Goeppert Mayer. Rudolf Peierls. George Placzek. Eugene Rabinowitch. Joseph Rotblat. Leo Szilard. Edward Teller. Stanislaw Ulam. John von Neumann. Victor Weisskopf. Eugene Wigner. These are just some of the scientists who had emigrated from Europe, many of whom later made critical contributions to the Manhattan Project – the American effort to build the world's first nuclear weapon.

Many of these scientists had seen firsthand the horrors Nazi Germany was perpetrating in Europe; many were Jews who were escaping persecution themselves. They showed their contempt for Adolf Hitler and his armies by bringing a sense of urgency to their research on the bomb, and were often motivated by what they believed the stake was: the fate of the world itself.

The Manhattan Project tested its first atom bomb on July 16, 1945, and delivered two to the U.S. military in July-August. Part of their sense of urgency was rooted in doubts about whether Nazi Germany was also building a bomb, including some groups led by the physicist and Nobel laureate Werner Heisenberg. The anxieties were not unfounded: in April 1945, only weeks before Germany surrendered to Allied forces, Heisenberg's team had assembled a nuclear reactor in a cellar beneath a church in Haigerloch, in the country's south.

The setup, called the B8 pile, had 664 cubes of uranium suspended on chains in around 1,400 litres of heavy water. A 40-cm-thick shell of graphite surrounded the core, and was itself surrounded by a layer of aluminium and a 60-cm-thick layer of (ordinary) water. The team had taken six years to build B8 but had little to show for it. When a few neutrons were shot into the reactor, the uranium multiplied them into more – but no chain reaction followed.

Far from critical

After the war ended, Heisenberg said the team had come very close; he wrote in a 1947 article in *Nature* that Haigerloch didn't have enough resources and that just a little more quantity of uranium would have done the trick.

According to a new study in *PNAS Nexus*, by researchers from the U.S., Heisenberg & co. were actually way off the mark.

Only around 14 of the 1,100 or so uranium cubes made for Heisenberg's efforts still survive. Using a pycnometer, the team found the density of one cube to be 18.535 g/cm3, lower than the 19.01 g/cm3 of solid uranium, indicating the cube was porous. Another cube contained 0.724% of uranium-235 (by mass), meaning it was natural rather than enriched uranium.

In March 1944, a German physicist named Karl Wirtz had reported that Nazi Germany's stocks of heavy water had accidentally been diluted to 98.85% purity. A post-war sample from Haigerloch in 1947 found only 96.8% purity. The team also started from the records of aluminium giant Norsk Hydro to estimate that Nazi Germany had a maximum supply of 1,836 kg of pure heavy water during the war.

When the team worked upwards from here, including the design of the B8 pile, they concluded it had a neutron

multiplication factor of 0.942. A reactor needs to have a factor of 1 to be critical. A difference of 0.058 is actually large. The team found that the uranium cubes in B8 were arranged too close together, preventing the heavy water from efficiently slowing the neutrons. The researchers estimated that increasing the heavy water's purity to 100% would improve the factor to only 0.95.

They also simulated over 1,200 combinations of uranium and heavy water and found that the B8 pile would have required at least 2,994 kg of uranium and 3,411 litres of heavy water to become critical. B8 however, contained 1,538 kg of uranium and 1,549 kg of heavy water when it was dismantled. More importantly, the team also estimated all German facilities at the time combined possessed only 2,572 kg of uranium and 1,890 kg of 96.8%-pure heavy water – a significant shortfall and which could support a factor of 0.959 at best.

The first U.S. reactor, called Chicago Pile-1, first became critical on December 2, 1942, using natural uranium as fuel and graphite, rather than heavy water, as the moderator. So some nuclear historians have opined that Heisenberg *et al.* had simply picked the wrong moderator.

A 2025 study in *The European Physical Journal H* demurred, however: while the U.S. was able to source petroleum coke extremely low in boron and turn it into reactor-grade graphite, the graphite made from metallurgical coke in Germany was high in boron, which absorbs neutrons. The B8 pile used the graphite from the predecessor B7 pile, and the new study also found that it contained 3.4 weight-parts per million (wppm) of equivalent boron contamination. The Siemens graphite from earlier contained around 6.6 wppm. On the other hand, the Manhattan Project used graphite with around 1.4 wppm of boron. In simulations, it didn't matter how far apart

the uranium cubes in the B7 pile or in any previous piles could have been: the contamination made criticality impossible.

The significant difference between the Nazi German and the Manhattan Project programmes, then, seems to have been industrial capacity. The Americans developed and built multiple technologies to enrich uranium, set up reactors and chemical separation units, and a weapons laboratory, which together created 1.3 lakh jobs and invested \$2.2 billion at the peak. Nazi Germany had nothing of similar scale.

According to a 2015 study in *Angewandte Chemie*, some uranium from the Nazi nuclear programme had not experienced a significant neutron flux and had probably come from Joachimsthal in today's Czechia, indicating (in a limited sense) the absence of an industrial uranium enrichment programme.

Many questions about the Nazi nuclear programme still remain open, often rooted in different interpretations of common data. Some important ones are centered on whether German scientists deliberately delayed the bomb project. Some technical questions are open, too. For example, the purity of the heavy water at Haigerloch itself is unknown and the graphite's boron content is based on archival rather than direct, firsthand information.

The overall picture today is neither that German physicists were incompetent nor that they were tantalisingly close to building a bomb. Their base of materials fell short of what a nuclear programme required and their supply chains were not good enough. Ultimately, given the information available at the time, and more so given Germany was also home to many of the world's best nuclear physicists, the Manhattan Project scientists' concerns were understandable.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“What is the meaning of ‘wicked’?”
“Wicked? Well, when you say that someone is wicked, it means that he/she is evil. He/she is behaving in a way....”
“I know that meaning of wicked! But does it have another meaning?”
“Another meaning? Well, I have heard....”
“...you see, today my cousin in America emailed me saying that the Harry Potter movie is wicked. What does he mean by that? How can a movie be “wicked”?”
“Well, what he means is that the movie is excellent. In informal contexts, the word ‘wicked’ is used to mean excellent.”
“Wicked means excellent? You are joking, right?”
“No, I am not. Native speakers of English use the word ‘wicked’ to mean ‘excellent or impressive’. For example, I can say, the masala dosa! that you get in that restaurant is wicked.”
“I bought some really wicked shoes last weekend. How does that sound?”
“Sounds great. But remember, this use of the word ‘wicked’ is restricted to informal contexts. It is considered to be slang by many people.”
“Ok, I’ll try and remember that. Let’s hope I get some....”
“.... where did you get that shirt? It’s really tight.”
“This shirt is not tight. Most of my friends have said that it’s a great shirt.”
“I agree. It is a great shirt. No doubt about it.”
“But you said it was tight. How can...”
“.... one of the meanings of ‘tight’ is excellent.”
“You mean ‘tight’ and ‘wicked’ mean the same thing?”
“That’s right. In informal contexts, they can both mean the same thing. “Look at those really tight shoes that the woman is wearing. How does that sound?”
“Sounds good to me. You must see Lord of the Rings. It’s really tight.”
“But when a person says, ‘ Those shoes are really tight, how do we know what he means? Does he mean that the shoes are really tight or...?’
“... I understand what you are saying. Well, I guess the meaning will depend on the context.”
“That makes sense.”
“That does make sense, doesn’t it? But what you are doing doesn’t.”
“What do you mean?”
“Well, with the exams around the corner, shouldn’t you be studying? Most of your friends are pounding the books.”
“Pounding the books? Does it mean studying very hard?”
“That’s right. When you ‘hit the books’, or ‘pound the books’, you study very hard. For example, my neighbour’s son has been pounding the books for over six months now.”
“I spent the entire weekend pounding the books.”
“You could also say, I spent the entire weekend hitting the books.”
“I’ve been hitting the books for over three months now.”
“It’s about time that you became a study animal.”
“A study animal? Does it mean someone who studies all the time?”
“Students refer to person who studies very hard as a ‘study animal’. People tell me that my friend Madhu is a study animal.”
“My sister has been a study animal.”
“Too bad you aren’t one.”
“I know. I wish I could become a study animal.”
Published in The Hindu on March 5, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test yourself on India’s show at the recently concluded Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1**
The 85-medal tally is India's second-highest ever haul at the Asian Games, following the record 107 at Hangzhou 2022. With which country did India tie for the gold medals with 21?
- QUESTION 2**
Who was the only Indian to win all three types of medals, and in which events?
- QUESTION 3**
At 15 years, 6 months, and 6 days old, who became India's youngest-ever gold medal winner?
- QUESTION 4**
Which sport gave India the maximum gold medals with five?
- QUESTION 5**
Apart from Neeru Dhandu in shooting, who else returned with two gold medals to his/her name?
- QUESTION 6**
Pincky Balhara and Suchika Tariyal won bronze medals in which contact sports?



Visual Question:
Identify this person. She became the first Indian woman to win an individual gold medal in which sport? REUTERS

- Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:**
1. Singeetham began his career as an assistant to which esteemed director?
Ans: K.V. Reddy
2. 'Dikkatra Parvathi' won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film in Tamil in 1974. On which Bharat Ratna's literary work was it based?
Ans: Rajaji (C. Rajagopalachari)
3. Singeetham had the honour of directing Rajkumar's 200th and Kamal Haasan's 100th film. **Ans: 'Devatha Manushya' and 'Raja Paarvai', respectively**
4. Of his 61 films, what is special about these four: 'Bhagyada Lakshmi Baramma', 'Samyuktha', 'Ghatothkachi' and 'Welcome Obama'?
Ans: He also composed the music
5. Name the 1985 biographical dance film based on the life of Sudha Chandran. **Ans: 'Mayuri'**
6. He was an executive director of

- which National Award-winning 1970 film? **Ans: 'Samskara'**
7. He is credited with creating the first dialogue-less feature film in 1987. **Ans: 'Pushpaka Vimana'** (Pushpak/Pesum Padam)
8. The famous song sequence 'Sundari Neeyum' from 'Michael Madhana Kama Rajan' was visualised differently. How? **Ans: It was filmed at 48 fps instead of the normal 24 fps to give it a romantic slow-motion feel**
9. What is special about 'Sing Geetham'? **Ans: All the dialogues are in a 'sing-song' format**
- Visual: This is a screengrab of Singeetham making a cameo with a bioscope to introduce a film with a song. Name the film. **Ans: 'Michael Madhana Kama Rajan'**
- Early Birds:** Arun Kumar Singh | G. L. Vadhera | Dodo Jayaditya | Sudhir Thapa | Sunil Madhavan

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Vicissitude:
a variation in circumstances or fortune at different times in your life or in the development of something

Synonyms: ordeal, misfortune, tragedy, challenge, trouble, adversity, difficulty

Usage: *She faced many vicissitudes after moving to a new city.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/vicissitude

International Phonetic Alphabet: /vɪsɪstɪtjuːd/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

From Page One

SC distances itself from Form 6 tweaks

Senior advocate Vikas Singh, for petitioner Rakesh Singh, urged the court to suspend the CEC or divest him of any authority till the Supreme Court took a final call on the petition. “But then, who will conduct elections? You have to file petitions keeping in mind the working of the Constitution,” Justice Bagchi responded. Mr. Singh submitted that it was a grave situation that threatened the very basis of democracy. He requested the court to grant an interim relief on the petition, saying the “country will burn”.

Issuing notice, the Chief Justice said the court would act on authenticated information regarding the allegations. “We will examine the records, look into the particular records. We would like to see some responses [from the EC] first,” Chief Justice Kant said on the plea for interim orders. Justice Bagchi added that the Supreme Court cannot be asked to “put the cart before the horse and presume that all the EC orders were issued unilaterally”.

Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service, and Term of Office) Act of 2023 provides that “no court shall entertain or continue any civil or criminal proceedings against any person who is or was a Chief Election Commissioner or an Election Commissioner...”

“A protection when in office is always understood. But the ‘was’ in the provision is perhaps only protection with regard to the President. It does not apply even to judges... Look at the Judges Inquiry Act,” Justice Bagchi observed.

Senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy, for petitioner Shailendra Mani Tripathi, pointed out that 30% of the electorate in Delhi and 25% of the electorate in West Bengal have been deleted in the SIR process.

Trio wins Nobel for optogenetics research

He reasoned that the molecule involved in detecting light might be, or linked to, a protein that lets certain charged ions enter cells.

The team of Mr. Deisseroth, who is at the Stanford University in U.S., published its first major result in 2005 using rat neurons, and a year later, the technique had its name: optogenetics. In 2007, Mr. Deisseroth’s group stimulated specific neurons in the brain of live mice with light sent through a slender fibre-optic cable, moving the mice’s whiskers. Since then, scientists have used optogenetics to identify networks in the brain involved in pain, attention, sleep, memories, and social behaviours.

In 2000, following his alga experiment, Mr. Hegemann approached Mr. Nagel, currently at the University of Würzburg in Germany, who confirmed the idea in an experiment. The team identified two proteins that were channels, and they opened when exposed to light. The scientists called them channelrhodopsin-1 and channelrhodopsin-2. Channelrhodopsin-2 in particular opened within 0.2 ms when light was shone on it, allowing positively charged ions to flow into a cell and produce an electric signal.

More demands on U.S. deal ‘very difficult’: FM

“So, when you are talking about trade imbalance being the sole criteria, to what extent beyond negotiation can you go? Negotiation used to be the only platform through which countries could highlight the discrepancies and lopsidedness,” the Finance Minister said.

However, the imbalance is now being sought to be addressed through other means, she said. “Tariffs have become weaponised. So I can probably take the same position, can I not, with China, because the trade with it is so lopsided? But no, you can’t. You will have to talk it out. You will have to negotiate and have a give-and-take,” she said.

SC refuses to stay case against Nicobar project

However, the Calcutta High Court had entertained writ petitions filed by former Union Environment Secretary Meena Gupta claiming that the project violated the Forest Rights Act, 2006, and highlighting severe environmental threats it may allegedly cause.

Justice Joymalya Bagchi, on the Bench along with Justice V. Mohana, said there should be some degree of filtration between what constitutes the security of the state and what involved commercial interests. “Preservation of culture is a constitutionally protected fundamental right. When you are talking about tribe cultures in Nicobar ecology... tribe culture requires constitutional protection,” he observed orally.

In May, the Calcutta High Court dismissed the Union government’s preliminary objections regarding the *locus standi* of Ms. Gupta, banking on the submission that she was not a local. The High Court had scheduled the case for November 25 and November 26 for hearing constitutional issues centring on fundamental rights and preservation of the tribal peoples’ way of life.

Senior advocate S. Muralidhar, for Ms. Gupta, said the Centre’s argument in maintainability of the writ petitions before the High Court has become academic as the tribal councils have already been impleaded.

Mr. Venkataramani said the tribes were integrated, and were not in the protected category. “There is a lot of international...” he said.

India, Switzerland to boost defence, nuclear ties: Modi

The two sides agree to extend visas, student permits based on equal treatment principles; other agreements promote research, innovation, and explore opportunities in transport, infrastructure

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India and Switzerland have identified new opportunities for cooperation in areas of defence and nuclear energy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said, following a bilateral meeting with Swiss President Guy Parmelin on Monday.

Agreements signed by the two sides included one to extend visa durations and student permits.

Mr. Parmelin is in India for a three-day visit to commemorate the first anniversary of the Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) between India and the four-country European Free Trade Association (EFTA), which came into force on October 1, 2025.

“Today, we identified new opportunities for cooperation in military exchanges and defence production,” Mr. Modi said in a statement following the meeting. “We also agreed to further deepen cooperation in nuclear energy.”

The two countries also signed an agreement on



Swiss President Guy Parmelin and Narendra Modi at a joint press meet at Hyderabad House in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

transport, mobility, and infrastructure. “We invite Swiss infrastructure companies to invest in India at a large scale and participate in capacity building, design, and manufacturing,” Mr. Modi said.

Mr. Parmelin is accompanied by a large business delegation, underscoring the Swiss business community’s desire to make the most of the TEPA. However, the Swiss President noted that there are unfinished aspects, which will spur further investments once complete.

“To continue stimulat-

ing investment, Switzerland hopes to conclude an investment protection agreement quickly,” Mr. Parmelin said. “In this context, it is equally important to achieve results in the discussions on intellectual property protection.”

Multiple-entry visas

The two countries signed five agreements, including Memorandums of Understanding (MoU) and Letters of Intent (LoI), across a wide variety of sectors, the External Affairs Ministry said.

The MoU on Migration

MP defends plan by simultaneous polls panel to meet CJI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Defending the study tour to the Supreme Court of India, DMK Rajya Sabha MP P. Wilson, a member of Parliament’s Joint Committee reviewing the simultaneous poll legislation, wrote in a letter to panel chairperson P.P. Chaudhary on Monday that seeking the views of the Chief Justice of India and Supreme Court judges was not “unconstitutional”.

The letter follows Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal’s claim on Thursday that the visit would be unconstitutional and against the separation of powers. The study tour was eventually cancelled.

Foregrounding the DMK’s opposition to simultaneous polls, Mr. Wilson said that his remarks in the letter are solely confined to the question of separation of powers. Mr. Wilson,

who played a central role in arranging for the study tour, said that the meeting was called off over political objections raised by “vested interests”.

Separation of powers, he wrote, does not mean the three organs operate in watertight compartments. “The Constitution does not establish three isolated islands,” he said. Seeking informal views is not the same as seeking adjudication, and the Committee was not asking judges to certify or pre-judge the Bill. He cited March 1948, when Federal Court judges and High Court Chief Justices met to formulate views on the Draft Constitution. He also pointed to Article 143, under which the President may seek the Supreme Court’s opinion on questions of public importance, and said the provision could not remain if the opposing argument held.

Set up 24-hour monitoring cells to curb sexual offences, SC tells police

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Underlining the need to take preventive measures against sexual offences, the Supreme Court on Monday asked the Delhi Police to set up 24-hour monitoring cells for continuous surveillance of vulnerable areas. The court also asked the police to strengthen patrolling, particularly around educational institutions and public spaces.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran observed that the mere installation of CCTV cameras in public spaces would serve little purpose without continuous monitoring to detect suspicious activity and enable a swift police response.

“When we are talking about surveillance through CCTV cameras, how far will they help curb crimes if there is no continuous monitoring at different war rooms? The cameras will



help you in catching hold of the culprit, but how will you prevent such crimes? There has to be a 24-hour cell which keeps monitoring what is happening,” the Bench observed.

The court was hearing a *suo motu* case concerning a spate of sexual assault incidents involving minors and women in the Delhi-National Capital Region. It had earlier indicated that it intended to fix accountability on authorities entrusted with preventing crime and protecting vulnerable persons.

“Focus on educational institutions, colleges,

Delhi police file FIR against those seeking action against ACP

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police on Monday registered an FIR against a journalist who has accused Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) Vivek Bhagat of sexual harassing and manhandling her while she was covering a protest. The FIR was also registered against 17 others, who were staging a demonstration along with the journalist, demanding the registration of a case against the police officer.

The action came shortly after they were detained for their protest outside Parliament Street police station on Monday. The journalist and protesters were initially taken to the Delhi Cantonment police station before being taken to different police stations in the New Delhi district. The charges filed against them included unlawful assembly, physical defacement or vandalism, obstructing a public servant from discharging duties and assaulting a police officer on duty, among others.

Meanwhile, Mr. Bhagat, was promoted to the rank of Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police in an order signed by the Deputy

Protesters came out in support of a journalist who said she was sexually harassed by officer

Secretary (Home) Ramesh Kumar. A senior police officer said the promotions are routine and the request for the promotions was sent some time ago.

The complaint alleging sexual harassment and manhandling by police has been transferred to the Crime Branch but no FIR had been registered, nearly 48 hours after the alleged incidents.

Police custody

The two women journalists among the protesters were released from Mandir Marg police station on Monday evening, while the remaining 16 protesters were kept in police custody and are expected to be produced before a Magistrate.

A New Delhi police official had also told *The Hindu* on Sunday that there was no evidence to substantiate the allegation.

Legal affairs head of the Cockroach Janta Party Ratna Singh alleged that the detainees were assaulted by the police.

Free speech case: top court may not hear reference on merits

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A seven-judge Constitution Bench may not commence hearing, on October 6, questions touching upon whether legislative privilege can stifle free speech, arising out of a 2003 Tamil Nadu Assembly resolution to arrest editors of *The Hindu* for an editorial criticising the then Chief Minister Jayalalithaa.

The Bench is convening on Tuesday, as scheduled, for the sake of formality, but would not proceed to hear the reference on merits.

The development came after senior advocate Raju Ramachandran, appearing for the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, made an oral mentioning before a

Bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant that the 2003 resolution was withdrawn the following year.

Mr. Ramachandran said the order of reference to the Constitution Bench does not reflect this particular fact about the withdrawal of the resolution.

“It is not noticed [in the court’s order of reference in August],” Mr. Ramachandran submitted.

He urged the Chief Justice to consider his preliminary objections against hearing the referral on the merits, saying it would only be an academic exercise.

Chief Justice Kant said the court did not want to get into a prolonged academic exercise, particularly when several other part-heard matters were pending.

Senior advocates Kapil Sibal and Amit Anand Tiwari, appearing for the petitioners, said the fact was indeed mentioned, but may not have been noticed.

Mr. Sibal said the Tamil Nadu issue specifically “may be dead”, but the larger question of legislative privilege versus free speech was very much alive and relevant. Chief Justice Kant suggested the case could be kept formally open in the court, to be taken up when an occasion arises in future.

The case dates back to 2003, when *The Hindu* had published the editorial, prompting the Assembly Speaker at the time to pass a resolution in the House accusing the daily of having “distorted the proceedings of the Assembly”.

CEC has lost public trust, must be removed: activists

D. Raja slams Gyanesh over 'changes to Form 6'

19,000 West Bengal voters to miss bypolls as appeals remain pending in tribunals

Rahul is 'spreading lies' over Form 6: BJP

Cong. to launch campaign against vote *chori*, help re-enrol deleted names

CM
YK

INBRIEF



Centre elevates three HC Chief Justices to top court

The Centre on Monday appointed the Chief Justices of the Gujarat, Delhi, and Telangana High Courts to the Supreme Court. The three additional judges will take the court's working strength to 37, leaving one vacancy against its sanctioned strength of 38. Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said on X that Justice Sunita Agarwal, Chief Justice of the Gujarat High Court; Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya, Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court; and Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh, Chief Justice of the Telangana High Court have been appointed to the Supreme Court. They are set to be sworn in on October 6.

150 Bangladeshis living illegally in J&K being deported: govt.

As many as 150 Bangladeshi nationals who were allegedly staying illegally in Jammu and Kashmir were shifted to West Bengal on Monday as part of their deportation process, officials said here. The officials said a survey conducted during which around 600 Bangladeshi nationals were found allegedly staying illegally in the Kashmir valley. They were sent to a camp manned by the Srinagar Police, from where they are being transported to Bagdogra for a final pushback to their country of origin, they said.

Plea in SC asks if States can redraw wards during Census

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to hear a petition questioning whether State governments can undertake a fresh delimitation of wards and alter the boundaries during an ongoing Census exercise.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant indicated listing the case on October 9 for hearing. The petition filed by Paka Suresh, a former Mayor of the Kadapa Municipal Corporation in Andhra Pradesh, said the question of law was of general public importance concerning the conduct of Census 2027, having national implications.

Rule 8(iv) of the Census Rules 1990 requires State governments to “freeze the administrative boundaries of districts, tehsils, towns, etc.” from the date intimated by the Census Commissioner.

Bharat Innovation Challenge returns for its second edition

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Bharat Innovation Challenge is back with its second edition. Organised and hosted by Lovely Professional University (LPU), the Bharat Innovation Challenge 2.0 urges students from Classes 8-12 aged between 13 and 18 years to participate and identify real-world problems and develop innovative, practical, and scalable solutions.

Season 2 has 10 innovation themes, 29 winning categories, ₹14 lakh in cash prizes, including a ₹3 lakh Grand Champion prize, along with theme-wise and special awards. The top teams will advance to the grand finale at LPU, to be held on November 20-21. Registrations and online submissions close on October 10.

Students can participate in teams of two-five, with one faculty mentor and develop solutions across 10 themes: Agritech & Rural Innovation, Healthcare &



HealthTech, Smart Living & Urban Intelligence, Cybersecurity & Ethical Tech, Education & EdTech, Climate & Sustainable Tech, Aerospace & Frontier Tech, AI & GenAI, FinTech & Financial Inclusion, and Social Impact, Culture & Heritage.

“India’s young minds have potential to turn today’s biggest challenges into tomorrow’s solutions. Through Bharat Innovation Challenge, we want to give school students a national platform where their ideas are encouraged, mentored and transformed into solutions with real impact,” Ashok Kumar

Mittal, founder-chancellor, LPU and MP (Rajya Sabha), said.

The competition will take place in two stages. Stage 1 involves online registration and submission of ideas through a power-point presentation or PDF. Entries will be evaluated on innovation, problem-solving, feasibility, impact, scalability and presentation. The top teams will advance to the grand finale, where students will showcase their innovations and pitch it before experts and industry leaders.

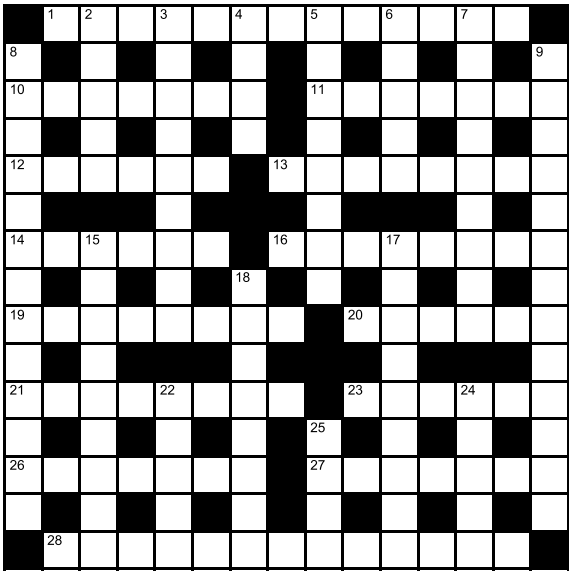
The initiative is supported by *The Hindu in School* as media partner, Quantiphi as AI Partner, Kangaro as stationery partner and Scarters as lifestyle partner. For registrations, the participants can email: bic@lpu.co.in and dial +919888598702 for further details.

The registration link is <https://www.lpu.in/bharat-innovation-challenge/> or scan the QR code.



THE CROSSWORD+ 14916
(set by Karaoke)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>



Across

- 1 Mrs. Henry rues uncontrollably while narrating unknown verses for children (7,6)
- 10 Where a train should be to make progress? (2,5)
- 11 Perfect to enjoy long time in retreat (7)
- 12 Lack of interest, of course, in any case (6)
- 13 Spooner's father gambles amounts that can never be recovered (3,5)

- 14 Before the end of day, fancy thing worn by women (6)
- 16 0° Celsius or 32° Fahrenheit from inception, maybe not new (3,5)
- 19 Skirts around central party's cocktails (8)
- 20 Programming specialist in school, skips advanced information engineering initially (6)
- 21 They guard the chests by taking extraordinary care with big guns at boundary (3,5)
- 23 Allowed nothing over board (6)
- 26 Hanging harmful revolutionary in dream (7)
- 27 Knock panda group at the midpoint? It's not possible (2,3,2)
- 28 Outstanding girl studies Hindi with difficulty (13)
- Down
- 2 Diehard setter opts out of ritual dance (5)
- 3 Something to eat during breaks over the table mainly perhaps with Karaoke (9)
- 4 Ignore boy, check for playboy (4)
- 5 Fact-finding coordinator at centre leaves his career in a fit of anger (8)
- 6 Why I say, silently leave trophy and admit defeat (5)
- 7 Found enjoyment, going topless, holding rounded clubs (9)
- 8 Some rural man confused about new CIVIL ID perhaps? (5,8)
- 9 Terrible loss for other Congress mainly when politicians join the opposite side (5,3,5)
- 15 Mock up one person without natural covering mostly in loose blouse (9)
- 17 Inspector shot main criminal for major offence within boundaries (9)
- 18 Mercenary from Edinburgh working to eliminate bishop (5,3)
- 22 Part of hospital is tailor-made for noted celebrities in the show business (1-4)
- 24 Heavy-weight wife leaves Newton, while cycling (5)
- 25 Two-toed sloth runs heartily on the banks of Anapu (4)

‘We need to foster a middle power approach’

India, a respected actor on the international stage, can help in finding a peaceful solution to the Ukraine war, says the French Minister-Delegate for European Affairs; stressing that India and France share a common attachment to multilateralism, he says the EU seeks de-escalation in West Asia crisis

INTERVIEW

Benjamin Haddad

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India and France have a common attachment to “strategic autonomy”, says French Minister-Delegate for European Affairs Benjamin Haddad, indicating that European countries are increasingly seeking more “middle power coalitions” to hedge against the uncertainty in ties with superpowers U.S. and China. In Delhi for the ‘Munich Leaders Meeting’, where External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar indicated for the first time that India is mediating between Russia and Ukraine for a specific agreement, Mr. Haddad said that he hoped India would use its “voice” to bring Russia to the table for peace talks.

You're in Delhi two months before the culmination of the India-EU FTA, which is

supposed to happen on December 16 in Brussels. Can you confirm that the date is now set, and are there any hurdles still to cross before that?

It's indeed our objective to close by the end of the year. France is very supportive of the FTA with India, which really shows the deepening of both a bilateral relationship and the broader relationship between the European Union (EU) and India. We are in a world of geopolitical turmoil, where we see that we have a common attachment to multilateralism, to cooperation, to a form of independence in international relations, which I think is what also brings France and India very close... this attachment to having strategic autonomy, to developing a sort of approach of middle powers in this world.

Do you see India and France coming together in some kind of a non-superpower coalition - with the middle powers versus the superpowers?



I don't think it's ‘versus’. I think we are attached to a world that's driven by reliable partnerships, by cooperation and multilateralism in international law. We have our traditional allies, and we are very committed to the European project, but we can see that with partners like India, we share the objective of not just being passive bystanders of a rivalry between the United States and China, but also to be able to defend our own interest. In areas like access to space and leadership of AI, I think there is really an incredible potential for a partnership. The India-EU FTA will only operationalise and deepen this. And

one of the reasons for my visits, my second visit this year, is beyond just the signature of [the FTA] document; [it] is to look at how we can take it to a stronger partnership and a common voice on the international stage.

An area of disagreement is the Russia-Ukraine conflict. What is your expectation from India, given it still imports more than half its oil needs from Russia?

I've seen Indian leaders state very clearly that they want to find a peaceful solution, including Prime Minister Modi, who told President Putin that it's time to

stop the wars. In this respect, a country like India, that is a respected actor on the international stage, can play a role in working with us to find a peaceful solution , but clearly Russia continues to refuse. The best way to put an end to this war is to increase the pressure on Russia to get it back to the negotiating table, and so it means also increasing economic pressures. We generally don't lecture other countries on what they should do, but at the European level, we have adopted different packages of sanctions.

The recent BRICS Summit ‘Delhi Declaration’ made no mention of the Ukraine war. Does this indicate that it is now just a European problem, not for the rest of the world?

It would be [a] mistake to think that. Of course it is a European issue, as it pertains to European security. [But] this is also about international principles, not just law, [but] of the security architecture that we want. If we allow a state to

invade its neighbour, to use nuclear blackmail to conduct a conventional war on its neighbours, it creates an extremely dangerous precedent for the rest of the world, including for the nations that were at this BRICS Summit.

The U.S. invasion of Iran earlier this year, the assassination of its Supreme Leader, of civilians there, targeting of nuclear installations, also ticks all these boxes, and yet no one is asking for the U.S. to be treated the same way...

Europeans are not involved in [the Iran] war. We have always called for de-escalation. We have always called to find peaceful and diplomatic solutions, whether that's on the freedom of navigation, the Strait of Hormuz, including on tackling issues where we agree with the U.S. for example, the Iranian nuclear programme, its ballistic missile programme, its support for terrorist proxies in the region. We said the best way is to do it through a diplomatic channel.

‘Hasina’s activities pose challenge to planning Bangladesh PM’s India trip’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
DHAKA

The activities of deposed premier Sheikh Hasina and her team pose the “principal challenge” to planning a visit to India by Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, State Minister for Foreign Affairs of Bangladesh Humaiyun Kobir said on Monday.

Responding to questions from *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the ongoing Bay of Bengal Conversation organised by Dhaka's Centre for Governance Studies (CGS), Mr. Kobir emphasised the importance of “strategic autonomy” for Bangladesh and said India has to appreciate the “challenges of a newly elected government” in Bangladesh.

“The visit will be bilateral but there are challenges and through dialogue we will overcome them. The principal challenge is not too much to ask for. Sheikh Hasina and her team are stationed in Delhi and they



Humaiyun Kobir

are trying to destabilise a foreign country sitting in Delhi. This does not benefit India either,” Mr. Kobir said, calling on India to restrain Ms. Hasina.

Mr. Kobir accused Ms. Hasina of killing around 2,000 Bangladeshi citizens during the crackdown of the uprising of July-August 2024 and described her as a “terrorist”.

He said Bangladesh's people need a “clean break” from the past as they have sacrificed lives in the process of overthrowing the previous government of Ms. Hasina that ruled for more than 15 years.

The Minister, however, said there are ongoing talks with India that have been welcomed in Dhaka.

“We are seeing some positive signs as India is trying to restrain them (Ms. Hasina and her group). That is the norm between two countries. If they are restrained, then there will be no problem in the [bilateral] relationship,” said Mr. Kobir asserting that ties with India are a priority for Dhaka. “The visit of Prime Minister will take place at a conducive time and I am hopeful. PM has never said that he will not visit [India],” said Mr. Kobir highlighting the role of Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi in this regard.

Indian envoy’s role “The Indian High Commissioner here is doing a good role. He is trying and hopefully Delhi will be receptive to his opinion and if they give importance to his opinion, then we are ready to engage across the board.

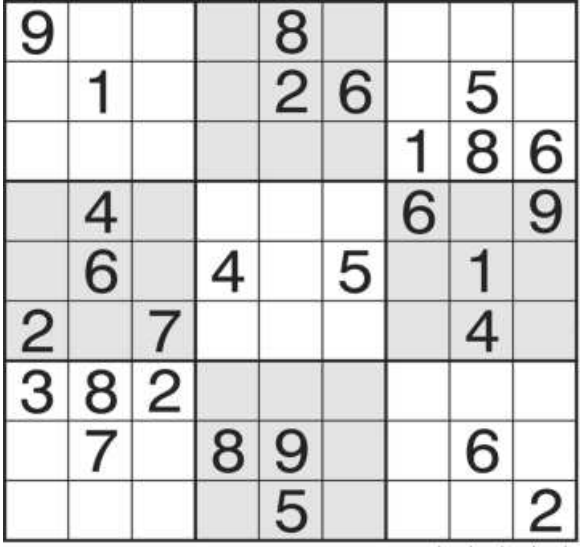
We are carrying out our consultations,” said Mr. Kobir describing the Awami League leadership as a “hindrance” to normalisation of New Delhi-Dhaka ties.

The State Minister of Foreign Affairs said that Bangladesh is ready to discuss all issues but expects some “reciprocation”. “When two governments sit down to discuss keeping in mind national interests, all issues can be addressed,” he said arguing that Bangladesh will not allow anyone to work against India's interest sitting in Dhaka and he expects similar action from India.

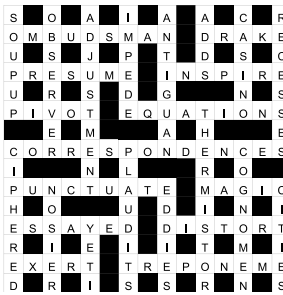
Earlier, Mr. Kobir delivered a “ministerial address” at the Bay of Bengal Conversation and said Bangladesh seeks “strategic autonomy” in foreign affairs but will maintain strong relation with global stakeholders.

(The correspondent is visiting Dhaka as a guest of the Centre for Governance Studies)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Selfless service

Lord Siva's penance has to be disrupted if He is to marry Parvati. And only if they marry, will Murugan take His avatara. So, Brahma asks Manmatha to disrupt Siva's tapas. Afraid of Siva's anger, Manmatha refuses, and Brahma uses his persuasive skills to convince Manmatha. He tells Manmatha that one must be selfless and must help those who need assistance, said Sumathi Sri in a discourse. He tells him the story of Dadhichi. When the war between the devas and the asuras came to an end, the devas left their weapons in Dadhichi's ashram, telling him that they would collect the weapons whenever a war broke out again. Many years passed, and since the devas did not come to take their weapons, Dadhichi dissolved the weapons in the sacred water in his kamandala, and drank it. As a result, his backbone became a strong weapon.

When Indra had to fight Vritasura, he went to retrieve the weapons. The sage told Indra that he had consumed the weapons, but Indra could use the sage's backbone to fashion a weapon. This meant that Dadhichi had to die. But he didn't mind dying for a good cause. He told Indra to take his backbone. The weapon known as Vajrayudha was made out of Dadhichi's bone. Brahma asks Manmatha to think of the ultimate sacrifice of Dadhichi. Shouldn't Manmatha think of others, instead of thinking only about himself? Brahma tells Manmatha about the churning of the milky ocean, and of Lord Siva's selflessness. When the Halahala poison emerged from the ocean, it posed a danger to everyone. To save everyone, Siva tried to swallow it, but Parvati clutched His throat, and the poison remained in His neck. That is why Siva is known as Neelakanta.

A ND-NDE

ADDIS ABABA

Eight killed in drone strike at camp for displaced people in Ethiopia



AP
A drone strike on a camp for internally displaced people in northern Tigray region in Ethiopia on Sunday killed at least eight people, a humanitarian source said on Monday. Fighting broke out between Tigray People's Liberation Front and federal forces on September 23, sparking fears of a return to the 2020-2022 civil war. AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. withdraws all bomber aircraft from U.K. airbase over 'new threats'



AFP
The U.S. on Sunday said that it had withdrawn all B-1 bombers from the British airbase of RAF Fairford, reportedly due to "new threats", with Britain's government insisting on Monday that the site is safe. A counter-terrorism probe was launched after a group was reported for "suspicious" activity near the base on September 27. AFP

LAGOS

Nigerian President confirms 32 dead after military plane crash



GETTY IMAGES/STOCKPHOTO
A Nigerian Air Force plane crashed on Monday in the country's southwestern Ondo state, killing all 32 people on board, President Bola Tinubu said. The passenger aircraft was on a "routine mission" from Benin City in southern Nigeria to the economic hub of Lagos when it went down at Igbokoda in Ondo state, he said. AFP

BEIJING

Philippines involved in 'provocative acts' in South China Sea, says China



AP
China warned Philippines on Monday against "provocative acts" in the disputed South China Sea, accusing a Philippine aircraft of an airspace violation. The Philippine forces said a Chinese fighter jet interfered with a "routine military patrol" carried out by a Cessna 208 turboprop near the Scarborough Shoal on Saturday. AFP

Brazil lurches to the right as Lula falters

President trailed his challenger Flávio Bolsonaro by about 1.8 percentage points, or 2.2 million votes; the right-wing Liberal Party broke voting records in Congress, emerged as the dominant force in the Senate and made significant gains in State assemblies; Lula and Flávio will face a run-off on Oct. 25

Shobhan Saxena
SAO PAULO

Sunday night was supposed to be historic for Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, who was seeking a record fourth term as Brazil's President. But when the results came in, the night looked gloomy. Instead of winning in the first round, as his supporters had expected, Lula trailed his challenger Flávio Bolsonaro by about 1.8 percentage points, or 2.2 million votes. With Flávio also falling short of the 50% needed for an outright victory, the election now moves to a second round on October 25 – leaving Lula facing a tougher contest than anticipated, while Bolsonaro heads into the runoff with the momentum of having finished first.



Men look at newspapers displaying coverage of Brazil's presidential election results at a newsstand in Rio de Janeiro on Monday. AFP

The two candidates struck sharply different notes as the results became clear. Flávio, the eldest son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, declared that Brazilians were demanding change. "It is the end of the era of the Workers Party (PT); it is a big change in our country," he told reporters in

Brasília. Lula, speaking to supporters in São Paulo, acknowledged that the result had been unexpected. "I confess to you that I was convinced I would win the election in the first round," he said. But Lula insisted that the contest had now entered a new phase. "The second round is a new campaign," he said, arguing

that the runoff would give voters a direct choice between the two candidates and their visions. Political pundits agree that the second round is a new election and can go either way. But there is little doubt that, for now, the momentum is with the right. As if Flávio staying ahead of Lula in the presidential election was not shocking enough for Brazil's left, the results for Congress, the Senate and State governors came as a big jolt too. Candidates from the Bolsonaros' Liberal Party (PL) broke voting records in Congress, while the party emerged as the dominant force in the Senate and made significant gains in State assemblies. Flávio's supporters also account for a majority of the governors elected in

the first round, pointing to a broad rightward shift that extends beyond the presidential race. But the most significant feature of the rightward shift may be that the PL has not grown at the expense of Lula's party. The far-right party has expanded its base by eating into the traditional conservative and centre-right political space. With 19 senators elected, the PL will increase its representation from 15 to 28 seats from February 2027, giving it the second-largest single-party bloc in the Senate since Brazil's return to democracy. While the left has maintained its position in the Chamber and Senate, the far right has grown by favouring much of the right. Another factor behind

Flávio's strong performance was the evangelical vote, which has increasingly consolidated behind the Bolsonaro family, while Lula failed to translate Brazil's large Catholic population into the electoral advantage his campaign had expected. The contrast was particularly striking after the controversy surrounding Nossa Senhora Aparecida, Brazil's patron saint, which became a political issue during the campaign. In municipalities with an above-average concentration of evangelicals, Flávio won 52% of the valid votes. The contrast was even sharper in municipalities with the highest concentration of Catholics. Lula's share there fell by 11 percentage points compared with his previous performance.

Pakistan, Turkiye to deploy forces in Saudi Arabia

Reuters
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkiye agreed on Monday to move immediately to implement their collective defence commitments and ensure the "rapid deployment" of agreed military forces and capabilities in Saudi Arabia, the three countries said in a joint statement shared by Pakistan's Foreign Ministry. The decision was taken at an emergency meeting of the Mecca Defence Alliance in Riyadh and would be carried out under "approved arrangements" and the laws of the three countries, the statement said. The meeting "reaffirmed the solidarity and unity of our countries in confronting the heinous at-

tacks against the Kingdom and the holy sites," Saudi Defence Minister said on X. The three countries signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement in August, under which an armed attack on one member is considered an attack on all. Forces of the Saudi-led coalition fighting in Yemen have recaptured several key areas around Bab el-Mandeb Strait from Iran-backed Houthi rebels, Yemeni officials said Monday. The offensive came just after the rebels said they had captured more territory in the southwestern Yemen, taking a key town in a blow to the Saudi-backed forces as they advanced toward a strategic provincial capital in the region. (With AFP inputs)

Sánchez calls early elections in Spain after housing protests

Associated Press
MADRID

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez announced early general elections on Monday, looking to seize momentum from housing protests that have roiled the country and frame the vote around issues that are favourable to his Socialist party. The election is scheduled for November 29 and will come roughly eight months earlier than originally planned. In recent weeks, Spaniards have demanded solutions for the country's



Spanish PM Pedro Sánchez

entrenched housing crisis, holding repeated protests in cities across the country after public outrage grew over the widely publicised eviction of an 87-year-old woman in Madrid last

month. Mr. Sánchez's government suffered a bruising legislative defeat last week after right-wing Opposition parties voted against emergency decrees introduced by his government to address evictions and real estate speculation. But if Mr. Sánchez's decision backfires, it would pave the way for a right-wing coalition of conservatives and the far-right Vox party, bringing an end to one of Europe's most prominent progressive governments and vocal critics of the Trump administration in the U.S.

Pneumonia death at plague institute in Siberia raises alarm

The Associated Press

Russian authorities have quarantined a hospital and are monitoring contacts of an employee at a plague research institute in Siberia who contracted pneumonia of an "unknown" cause. Local state TV said the woman died last week. Russian authorities said they found no evidence that her illness was caused by any of the pathogens she worked with. But the case has raised alarm in Russia after unconfirmed media reports suggested

she might have died of pneumonic plague – a less common but severe form of plague that can spread from person to person. The woman worked at the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Research Institute of Siberia in the Far East in Irkutsk, southeastern Siberia. Irkutsk Gov. Igor Kobzev said called it a suspected case of "a particularly dangerous infection." U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Monday he did not think there is cause for alarm, but the U.S. was closely watching.

Two dead, 11 rescued as ship catches fire, sinks in Black Sea

Agence France-Presse
BUCHAREST

Two crew died and 11 were rescued on Monday after a fire broke out on a ship in the Black Sea which later sank, Romanian authorities said. The cause of the fire was not given. The Black Sea has become a battlefield for increasing drone attacks in the Russia-Ukraine war. A Romanian naval spokesperson named the ship as the 139-metre long Royad Mammadov and the interior ministry said it sank about 30 nautical



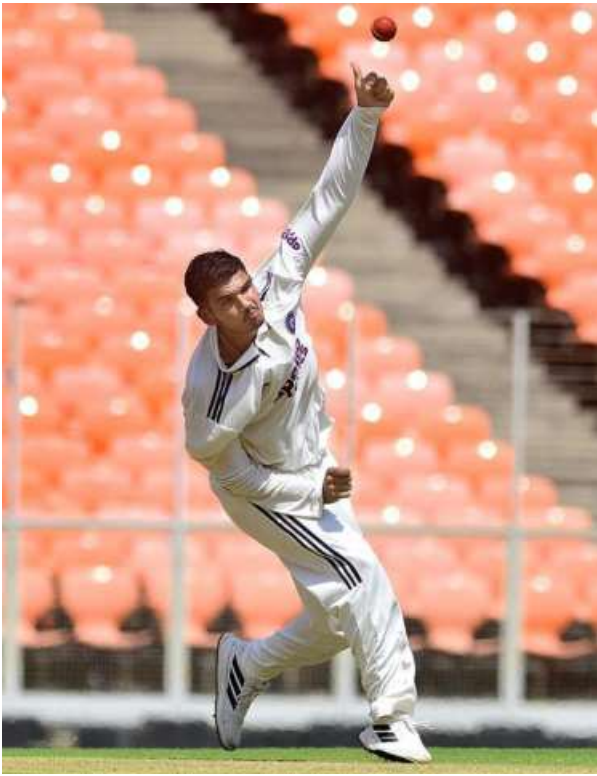
A Romanian naval spokesperson said the ship, Royad Mammadov, sank about 30 nautical miles south of Sfântu Gheorghe. REUTERS

miles south of the fishing port of Sfântu Gheorghe. Asked if the vessel was hit by a drone, the Defence Ministry did not reply. Ukraine President Volo-

dymyr Zelensky claimed that Russian drones struck the "civilian vessel carrying corn". He said Azerbaijani and Indian nationals were on board.

Sport

Baloda's six-for leaves the Aussies in a bind



Wheeling away: Baloda's toil reaped rich dividends. VIJAY SONEJI

AUS U-19 IN INDIA
Sahil Mathur
AHMEDABAD

Tanmay Baloda had a long, laborious day. The left-arm spinner bowled 25 overs, including 18 in his first spell. But it was all worth it when he leapt in joy after picking up a six-wicket haul on the opening day of the second youth Test between India under-19 and Australia under-19 here at the Narendra Modi Stadium on Monday. Baloda finished with six for 32 and helped the host bowl out the visitor for 174. India u-19 ended the day 136 runs behind, but lost openers Lakshya Raichandani and Sagar Virk to bring Australia back in the game.

Baloda had taken centre stage earlier. The 18-year-old broke three acts of resistance from the Australians. The first came when Neel Patel (31) and Eli Brain put on 22 after Priyanshu Singh and Mohit Ulva reduced Australia to 28 for two. Baloda immediately trapped Brain in front for four, and when Neel danced down the track, the wicketkeeper stumped him. From the other end, Ayaan Akram had Blake Cattle poking, while Baloda had Zed Hollick caught behind. After Australia lost four wickets inside five overs, Charlie Henderson (37) and Jacob Pietz (26) put up the second act. The duo, solid in defence, tested India's patience, adding 70 runs off 242 deliveries for the seventh wicket.

However, right after tea, Baloda broke through Pietz' defence, and soon Akram had Henderson caught at first slip. But Australia fought back through Thomas Vaseo and Patrick Sullivan. Baloda, though, did what he had done throughout the day – break the tailenders' resistance. The scores: Australia u-19 174 in 73 overs (Tanmay Baloda 6/32) vs. India u-19 38/2 in 15 overs. Toss: India. LIVE TELECAST India vs West Indies: First T20I, Star Sports 2 & JioHotstar, 7 p.m. Football: International friendly, India vs Uruguay, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 7.30 p.m. Nations League: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 12.15 a.m. (Wednesday)

An opportunity for the 'A' team players to stake claim in ODIs

AUSTRALIA-A IN INDIA
Anish Pathiyil
PUDUCHERRY

In 366 days, India will step onto the park for its 2027 ODI World Cup opener against Australia in Cape Town, South Africa. The 'A' squads of both nations will contest a three-match one-day series starting at the Cricket Association of Pondicherry Stadium on Tuesday, hoping to book a ticket to the plateaus of southern Africa next year. The countdown to the global tournament will seem to be ticking faster for these players, as opportunities to stake a claim for selection diminish with each passing day. Both In-

dia and Australia have fairly settled squads in the 50-over format, leaving only a few spots up for grabs. The India-A squad for the one-dayers wears a similar look to the one that participated in a tri-series involving Afghanistan and Sri Lanka in June. Among those added was all-rounder Hardik Pandya. The series was a critical step to gauge his fitness ahead of the New Zealand tour later this month. But a reported shin injury has ruled him out. Mumbai's Suryansh Shedge has been named his replacement. Jharkhand's Anukul Roy has replaced Naman Dhir, who has been added to the squad for the West Indies T20Is. "There is a lot of flexibility in this squad. All these

players are multi-dimensional and can fit into any role," said India-A coach L. Balaji. "India-A is a direct pathway toward the international stage – you saw Anshul Kamboj getting an immediate opportunity. BCCI has been phenomenal in scheduling these opportunities for youngsters," he added. Only six players remain from the Australia-A side that lost the multi-day leg O-1 a few days ago. A fresh set of pacers, including the uncapped Mahli Beardman, will have the chance to improve their stocks ahead of a World Cup year. The first match of the one-day series will be a day-night contest, starting at 2 p.m.

GAME PLAN

Men in Blue will look to rotate the players, says Morkel



SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

India's bowling coach Morne Morkel said the team will look to rotate the players. "I'm pretty sure (head coach) Gautam (Gambhir) will look to rotate (them). It is up to the selectors, the coach, and the captain to decide which XI will be the best to win a game on home soil. That will always be the main focus".

ADMIRABLE ATTITUDE

Bowling coach Morkel all praise for rookie pacers Prince and Mayank



SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Prince (Yadav) was a net bowler a couple of years ago. He's now playing for India; the resilience and hard work he's put into his game is admirable. Mayank (Yadav) had a couple of injury setbacks; for a youngster to get through that and play again for India shows real attitude — India's bowling coach Morne Morkel.

PRESTIGIOUS HONOUR

Kumkum and Sujeet named first winners of IOA awards



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Archer Kumkum Mohod and wrestler Sujeet Kalkal have been named the inaugural recipients of the Jaspal Rana Award and Raja Randhir Singh Award, respectively, by the Indian Olympic Association (IOA). They have been rewarded for their outstanding performances at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

FILLIP

A good result is important as it builds confidence, says Jamil



K.R. DEEPAK

India football coach Khalid Jamil stressed on the importance of the result in building confidence. "The result is important because if you get a good one, it gives the team confidence. But we also have a plan to build a strong team for the future," Jamil said ahead of the Uruguay game.

West Indies could run India close in five-match T20I series

The host boasts of a power-packed batting line-up; Samson under the scanner; how the team management handles Sooryavanshi will be interesting; the visitor gets a big boost with the return of Hetmyer, Powell, Shepherd and Akeal

WI IN INDIA

S. Dipak Ragav
LUCKNOW

For quite a while now, a lot of ink has been spilt on the packed schedule, especially for Team India. The country is blessed with an immense pool of talent, so much so that it can easily field multiple squads across formats. While that is often used to justify the gruelling fixtures, the powers that be need to seriously think about how much is too much.

Just two days after beating Pakistan to secure a gold medal at the Asian Games, Shreyas Iyer's men will be out on the park again to take on West Indies in a five-match T20I series that starts at the Ekana Stadium on Tuesday.

The Men in Blue's record in T20Is since the World Cup triumph earlier this year has been mixed. The side lost six games on the bounce in completed games, including a shock



Big question: Will the Indian think-tank prefer Sooryavanshi over Samson? SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

0-2 defeat to Ireland followed by another wipeout in England (0-4). Following that, India breezed past Zimbabwe (3-0) and, more

recently, Afghanistan (3-0). Now this assignment offers a chance to test the squad against a formidable Caribbean outfit. The host has a

power-packed line-up that bats deep, including all-rounders Shivam Dube and Nitish Kumar. It is complemented by the potent spin combination of Kuldeep Yadav, Ravi Bishnoi and Axar Patel. Arshdeep Singh will lead the pace attack, with Prince Yadav and Mayank Yadav being the other quicks.

However, one player who is under scrutiny is Sanju Samson. The wicket-keeper-batter has had a lean run since the World Cup, barring his two half-centuries against Afghanistan. With the next T20 World Cup scheduled in late 2028, it is an ideal time to experiment and groom the next batch. One thing to watch is how the think-tank handles Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and helps him find his feet in international cricket.

The visitor will hope to put the ODI series defeat behind it. The return of T20 specialists like Shimron Hetmyer, Rovman Powell and Romario Shepherd adds the much-needed firepower. On their day,

any one of the trio can take the game away from the opposition quickly.

The bowling, too, will be bolstered by the addition of left-arm spinner Akeal Hosein, who had an impressive IPL for Chennai Super Kings. Though India will start as favourite, Shai Hope's men will be keen to give the home team a run for its money.

The teams (from):

India: Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma (Vice-capt.), Abhishek Sharma, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Ishan Kishan (wk), Sanju Samson (wk), Shivam Dube, Kuldeep Yadav, Axar Patel, Naman Dhir, Ravi Bishnoi, Nitish Kumar, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav.

West Indies: Shai Hope (Capt. & wk), Jewel Andrew, Roston Chase, Matthew Forde, Shimron Hetmyer, Akeal Hosein, Shamar Joseph, Gudakesh Motie, Keemo Paul, Kamil Pooran, Rovman Powell, Sherfane Rutherford, Quentin Sampson, Romario Shepherd, Shamar Springer, Amir Jangoo (wk).

The dates: Oct. 6 (Lucknow), Oct. 9 (Ranchi), Oct. 11 (Indore), Oct. 14 (Hyderabad), and Oct. 17 (Bengaluru).

Matches start at 7 p.m.

India looks to bounce back as it faces the Uruguay test

FOOTBALL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

The most high-profile international chapter in Indian football ends with perhaps its most intriguing test when the national team meets two-time World champion Uruguay at the Salt Lake Stadium on Tuesday. The Blue Tigers have already faced Panama and Brazil in this window, holding the Central Americans to a 1-1 draw before suffering a 0-4 defeat at the hands of the five-time World Cup winner.

Uruguay provides another test of how far Khalid Jamil's side can compete against an opponent with considerably greater stature and international experience.

Jamil has a squad built around experience and emerging players. Forward Ryan Williams, who gave up his Australian citizenship to play for India, will be the principal attacker after scoring against Panama. Manvir Singh, Edmund Lalrindika and Vikram Partap Singh provide further options in the final third.

In midfield, Anirudh Thapa's return adds experience alongside Apuia and Sahal Abdul Samad. After the lessons of the Brazil game, India will need discipline without the ball and greater efficiency when opportunities arrive.



Danger man: Nunez is likely to keep the Indian defence busy on Tuesday. K.R. DEEPAK

Uruguay coach Diego Forlan urged his side not to be complacent against India, insisting the host deserves respect despite the gulf in standard between the two sides. "We know it's going to be really difficult, but we always respect everybody," Forlan said on Monday, the eve of the international friendly.

Uruguay comes into the game after a 1-3 defeat to Japan and a 4-1 win over South Korea, with Forlan stressing that his team has had more time to recover. After more than two decades of service to his country, the 39-year-old will hand over the captain's armband for good as he makes his final appearance in the Albiceleste jersey at the Estadio Monumental. Messi will be joined for his swansong by 85,000 spectators and several of the teammates with whom he reached the pinnacle of football at the World Cup in Qatar, alongside members of Argentina's emerging generation.

Nunez will pose the

Akeal confident Windies will push India

S. Dipak Ragav
LUCKNOW

West Indies spinner Akeal Hosein expressed confidence that his side would push India, the reigning T20 World champion, hard in the five-match series starting on Tuesday.

"I back my boys. Even when we played in the World Cup, we gave them a hell of a run. They know the fear that we bring to T20 cricket. They know the brand that we play. We know they are a dangerous team, but we're not going to back down," said Akeal.

"I would think both teams are looking forward to the challenge. It's about who plans best and who executes best. We are going to focus on the things that we can control. "

The 33-year-old is set to play in his 100th T20I match on Tuesday, and the Trinidadian hoped he could continue for another five years. "I wish I could see the next five years. But for me, first of all, I'm still at 99. I have to get selected to make that 100 game. That being said, it's an achievement in itself. It shows you're dedicated, you're hungry, and your performances have been up to par, too. So it's a good achievement," said Akeal.

Need to strike a balance between continuity and exposure, says Morkel



Task ahead: Morkel and Gambhir will have to put on their thinking cap. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

S. Dipak Ragav
LUCKNOW

India bowling coach Morne Morkel felt that the five-match T20 series against the West Indies would provide a good platform to develop the country's next batch of players in this format.

"Yes, it will be great for Indian cricket if we keep on growing that pool, keep on giving guys that experience and the taste of what it is to play in an Indian shirt," said Morkel.

"The main goal will always be to win games. This group of players has played some exceptional cricket

in the last couple of years. The guys who got opportunities have done a brilliant job.

"So it is about looking at the bigger picture, but you also want to win games with them. You want to give the guys who have done well so far the chance to continue that," he added.

On Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's development, Morkel was of the opinion that being around the team will be useful for the youngster even if he doesn't make it to the XI.

"If he's not getting that game time, he's still on a bus, in the dugout, in the

hotel with guys who have a lot of experience. Vaibhav sharing that sort of dressing room and talking to guys, watching how they go through their processes and how they set up an innings will be key.

"I'm a big believer that if you put guys in the right environment, they can ask the right questions and observe. I always ask him on the bus, 'What's the one thing you've learned today? Tell me, what did you think about that guy's batting?' That makes him think. The next time he comes to the nets, he will observe those things and adapt," said Morkel.



Messi is the Albiceleste's leading scorer (125) and most capped player (207). FILE PHOTO

Last hurrah for Messi in Argentina colours

Agence France-Presse
BUENOS AIRES

Lionel Messi will bring the curtain down on his glittering Argentina career on Tuesday with a friendly against Benin that marks the dawn of a new era for the South American champion.

After more than two decades of service to his country, the 39-year-old will hand over the captain's armband for good as he makes his final appearance in the Albiceleste jersey at the Estadio Monumental. Messi will be joined for his swansong by 85,000 spectators and several of the teammates with whom he reached the pinnacle of football at the World Cup in Qatar, alongside members of Argentina's emerging generation.

India can hurt Uruguay if given time and space: Forlan

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Uruguay coach Diego Forlan urged his side not to be complacent against India, insisting the host deserves respect despite the gulf in standard between the two sides.

"We know it's going to be really difficult, but we always respect everybody," Forlan said on Monday, the eve of the international friendly.

Uruguay comes into the game after a 1-3 defeat to Japan and a 4-1 win over South Korea, with Forlan stressing that his team has had more time to recover



Doing the hard yards: It remains to be seen whether Cardozo gets to guard the Uruguayan citadel. K.R. DEEPAK



Jamil. K.R. DEEPAK

Jamil urges India to stay focused

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

India head coach Khalid Jamil has urged his players to maintain concentration throughout the game as the team prepares to face two-time World champion Uruguay at the Salt Lake Stadium on Tuesday.

Acknowledging the quality and experience of the Uruguayan side, Jamil warned that even a single mistake could prove costly against an opponent strong at both ends of the pitch.

"Against Uruguay, we have to start with good concentration and maintain it from the first minute till the end of the game. We have to believe that we can get a good result," he added.

Grit, gold and a house that kabaddi built

A player-turned-coach, Neeta Dadwe has spent decades learning the game, building teams and pushing the women's game towards a promising future

Anirudh Velamuri

Gold. Silver. Bronze. Brass. It all gleams at you the moment you step inside. A towering cabinet blazes with medals, cups, and memorabilia, every piece neatly in its place. Flanking it stand trophies as tall as a small child, too big to fit anywhere and too important to hide. “Kabaddi gave me this house. Everything you see here is what the sport has given me. All of it is a result of my hard work,” declares Neeta Dadwe, pride lighting up her face.

To understand the woman behind that wall of silverware, step out of the house and onto the road that leads to it. A quiet bylane in the heart of the city, far from the roar of Hyderabad's traffic, it tips steeply downhill, as if to remind you that you are indeed standing on the Deccan plateau.

At first glance, it's unremarkable. Only, it isn't. This is a roll call of Indian sport and power. Two-time Olympic medallist P.V. Sindhu, India's first woman Grandmaster Koneru Humpy, and former cricketer Venkatapathy Raju all live in these bylanes. C.V. Anand, Telangana's Director General of Police, is a resident too, while Karnam Malleswari, the first Indian woman to win an Olympic medal, once called it home.

And somewhere amid all that star power lives Neeta, who has just led India's women's kabaddi team to gold at the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan.

The reinvention

An Arjuna Awardee with a stellar playing career, she reinvented herself as a coach and never looked back, guiding the national side to gold at the 2014 Asian Games and the 2016 South Asian Games.

Her name may not echo as loudly as those of her neighbours, but the shine of her achievements is every bit as bright. A day after she landed in the City of Pearls to a roaring welcome at the airport, *The Hindu* stepped into her cozy home for a conversation.

The Indian women's kabaddi team defeated Iran 37-34 in a closely fought final, successfully defending the gold medal it won at the Hangzhou edition in 2022. As captain Pushpa Rana, all-rounder Jyoti Thakur and several other players revealed after the triumph in Japan, the groundwork for this success was laid at carefully planned training camps.

“Our first camp was at SAI Gandhinagar in May for one month. We had 42 girls and brought it down to 29 there, which was a tough task for us on the selection committee - which includes Mamata Poojary and V. Tejeswini Bai. The next camp was for 15 days, again at SAI Gandhinagar, while the third was at the JSW facility in Ballari,” Neeta recalled.

“We got stuff like a fitness trainer, masseur, sauna bath, ice bath, and more, which is not common for us in kabaddi. I was the coach in 2014 (Asian Games) and we didn't have as many facilities as we got this time. The kids were very happy because our camps were like international ones. And because of that, for probably the first time, we barely had any injuries during the tournament.”

No mobiles, please

Besides physical and mental training, video analysis and tactical discussions, the team followed a 'no mobile phones' policy during the camps.

“We asked the federation and got their permission to do it. The more you use your mobile, especially later in the night, the more you will feel tired the next day. We got the players very much involved in it. One girl would take turns to collect the phones and deposit them. They would get them on Saturday and by Sunday's end, they would be returned.”

What they could not prepare for, and what has since been widely reported, were the poor living conditions that awaited them. The entire contingent was put up on a docked cruise ship, and it wasn't as luxurious as it sounds.

“The schedule was very tight for us, and the ground was very far from the ship where we were put up. To be honest, not everyone fits [in the accommodation provided] on the ship. Food was also an issue. Non-vegetarians didn't have a problem, but the vegetarians faced many. However, the girls managed to face it all without many complaints,” Neeta explained, adding that bread became a staple of her diet there.

On the mat, however, things were largely smooth. The side breezed past its group-stage and semifinal opponents before running into a familiar rival, Iran, in the final. India made a bright start and



raced to a 5-2 lead, before Iran levelled with a super tackle and surged ahead 7-5.

In the side's closest contest in Japan, it had a vocal crowd behind it, including members of the Indian Olympic Association, headlined by its president P.T. Usha.

“P.T. Usha came to watch our match. The whole of IOA came. We were all very tense. I was so tense that I couldn't even look back [at the stands]. The girls and I were under a lot of pressure, but we all had the same goal, which was to win the gold medal,” she admitted.

“In 2018 we won silver. Besides that, we won gold in 2010, 2014, and 2022. I was very scared and worried about how we would fare this time. Not just because of past results, but also because we selected a strong team this time and had good camps.”

Among the things that helped the team get past the Iranians was video footage of their time in India in the months leading up to the Asiad.

“They had been practicing in India for two months. They were in Himachal, played with two or three clubs in Haryana. We asked the federation for some of their videos, and we studied them well.”

For this Asian Games, Neeta was assisted by Mamata, someone she had coached extensively before, including at the 2014 edition of the continental competition. While that familiarity helped in discussing tactics, the two also shared the same nervous tension as the campaign kicked off.

“We used to sit at night and map on a piece of paper who should be played where. And on the first day there, neither of us slept because we were tense. If we used Ritu Negi in the corner pool, then they [the opponents] would've made a strategy for it. So we changed things up to give others some food for thought. In the end, we were working towards bringing the country a medal. We were not playing for our States or for Railways or anything. We were representing India.”

Neeta has coached the Indian women's side to two Asian Games golds, but can't bring herself to compare both. “Zameen aasman ka farak hai” (a world of

difference) came the declaration.

“The emotions involved are very different. In 2018, Iran edged India narrowly in the final. They were coached by our very own Shailaja Jain, who taught them exactly how to play against us. Also, there is a lot more competition now. Look at how well Nepal (lost to India in the semifinals) did. No one expected that.”

Having excelled as a player and a coach, how does Neeta compare the two experiences? “A player and a coach are different. A player gets to enjoy more; I was one, I know it very well,” she grinned.

Neeta the player greatly helped Neeta the coach. She channelled those experiences to help gel better with the team and structure training sessions in ways that kept players wholeheartedly involved. That also included keeping the workload relatively light in the days leading up to the tournament.

Fitness, however, was one area where there were no compromises.

“When I was a player, we used to make a fitness schedule. And on the days we had to do fast training or speed workouts, those days we used to cry or make excuses. So I told my girls upfront that I did not want to hear any excuses. I said we are all working towards a common goal and that they can express their feelings freely. And to be fair, they also supported me well in this endeavour.”

Professional pathway

While interest in kabaddi took off with the launch of the Pro Kabaddi League in 2014, it is the men who have reaped the rewards, while the women's ecosystem is yet to get an equivalent. A Women's Kabaddi Challenge was held in 2016, but it was a flash in the pan.

“In 2016, we had the Kabaddi Challenge, but it took place in the men's court. If there are three steps in a women's court, there are five in the men's court. And many argued that since volleyball and basketball have same-sized courts for men and women, why not kabaddi? But I believe that if that Challenge took place in a women's court, it would have been a big success,” she opined, adding, “If Pro Kabaddi starts for girls, it will be beneficial as more kids will

come out in the ecosystem.”

PKL's format has allowed the best international stars to ply their trade in India, which has not only helped coaches here understand how they operate but also helped Indian players improve by rubbing shoulders with them. Neeta believes the same knock-on effect would carry over to women.

“Besides getting to know the foreign players better, we will also get better in terms of fitness, nutrition, and more. Pro Kabaddi also provides players with great facilities; I have seen it. In India, after cricket, it is kabaddi only.”

That said, Neeta explained that the women have enough tournaments to keep them busy all year round.

“We had the World Cup earlier. From 21st to 31st this month, we have the Commonwealth Kabaddi Championship in Ahmedabad. After that, we have the Indo-Asian Games in Dubai in November. After that, there's the World Cup again. There is something or the other continuously; it's not like before.”

“Kabaddi, as you know, is not a game for rich people. I have seen kids come from nothing. Take Aslam (Inamdar) and so many other boys and girls. He told me that there was a time when he did not even get to eat; only he knows what all his mother did for him. He told me his story. If kids benefit from [getting a professional league], it's a matter of pride for them. They can then come up in life thanks to kabaddi.”

The Indian women's kabaddi team has clearly benefited from a coach who has walked many a mile in their shoes, back when chances were rare, the spotlight was dim, and the money was thin. That road made Neeta who she is.

And as the interview wound down, she threw in a reminder that it wasn't time for her to rest just yet. For she had already packed for the next stretch: a family road trip to her hometown, Nagpur, home to a local club, the Maratha Lancers, which first lit the fuse on her career.

THE GIST

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An Arjuna Awardee with a stellar playing career, she reinvented herself as a coach and never looked back, guiding the national side to gold at the 2014 Asian Games and the 2016 South Asian Games

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▼
While interest in kabaddi took off with the launch of the Pro Kabaddi League in 2014, it is the men who have reaped the rewards, while the women's ecosystem is yet to get an equivalent



New discovery comes ‘close’ to test biology’s central dogma

The discovery of a protein that can, by itself, dictate the sequence of nucleic acids has caused a stir in the scientific community; commentaries accompanying the work have highlighted the unusual nature of the finding and its implications for one of the foundational ideas of molecular biology

Arun Panchapakesan

The field of molecular biology began when scientists attempted to answer a simple question: what molecule makes up the genetic material of an organism?

In the early 1900s, when the field was still in its infancy, there were two plausible candidates: nucleic acids (DNA and RNA) and proteins. At the time, proteins were the preferred candidates thanks to their diverse building blocks.

All proteins (on the earth) are made up of some combination of 20 amino acids. Nucleic acids on the other hand were made up of just four nucleotides, leading to fewer molecular combinations than scientists believed were necessary for the carriers of heredity.

In 1944, three scientists – Oswald Avery, Colin MacLeod, and Maclyn McCarty – showed that when you destroy the proteins and the RNA in certain pathogenic bacteria, something still remains – and mixing that mysterious something with non-pathogenic bacteria could ‘turn’ them into pathogenic ones.

But when you specifically destroy the DNA, the transformation does not happen.

The central dogma

The final nail in the coffin for proteins came in 1952 when Alfred Hershey and Martha Chase used bacteriophages – viruses that infect bacteria – and showed that when you radioactively label the phage DNA with phosphorus and its proteins with sulphur, you could find phosphorus inside the bacteria that the phage infected, but never the sulphur. The phosphorus was even present in subsequent generations of the phage produced by the infected bacteria, showing that DNA was the genetic material.

Soon afterwards, James Watson and Francis Crick proposed the double helical structure for DNA, and their model also explained how one strand helical strand can be used as a template to synthesise the other.

However, finding the answer to molecular biology’s foundational question opened a Pandora’s box of new questions. One of those questions was how the chemical information present in DNA was used to make proteins. At the time, scientists knew that proteins were the ultimate workhorses of the cell and performed all the cellular tasks. However, they did not know how the cell made proteins based on the instructions in the DNA.

In 1958, Crick, with remarkable foresight, proposed what he called the “central dogma” of molecular biology. In a paper in the journal *Symposia of the Society for Experimental Biology*, Crick wrote that “once ‘information’ has passed into protein, it cannot get out again”. He further elaborated that the core principle behind the central dogma was that the “transfer of information from nucleic acid to nucleic acid, or from nucleic acid to protein, may be possible, but transfer from protein to protein or from protein to nucleic acid is impossible.”

Crick used the general term for DNA and RNA collectively, i.e. nucleic acid, rather than DNA alone, because by that time scientists knew that some viruses used RNA as the genetic material. In all other forms of life, RNA serves a different purpose.

An unbeaten rule

Today, we know that cells use the information in the DNA to make a messenger molecule, called mRNA, which then serves as the instruction manual for the cell to make proteins.

The mRNA is a transient intermediate: a cell can stop making it if required and can degrade it if it needs to stop protein production. This way, the cell preserves the instructions in the DNA, makes a copy of the DNA into RNA, and makes protein from RNA.

But when Crick suggested the central dogma, scientists did not fully understand the role of mRNA. The DNA to RNA to protein flow sequence was only elucidated in 1961, and that sequence itself came to be known as the central dogma of molecular biology.

But one wrinkle turned up in 1970. U.S. biologists Howard Temin and David Baltimore reported the discovery of retroviruses – a new family of viruses that used RNA as the genetic material, but then made a DNA copy of it using an enzyme called reverse transcriptase, then mixed this DNA with the DNA of the host. The viruses then continued the ‘DNA to



Cells use the information in DNA to make a messenger molecule, called mRNA, which then serves as the instruction manual for the cell to make proteins. Representative illustration. IMAGE MADE WITH AI

RNA to protein’ sequence. However, the starting point was RNA, and technically, information was flowing backwards along the sequence before it flowed in the conventional way, supposedly violating the central dogma.

The discovery stirred significant debate in the scientific community, and researchers published several articles along the theme of how the central dogma had been violated. Weeks later, Crick himself wrote another paper explaining in greater detail how his guidelines for the central dogma still held, and how, even in his original 1958 paper, he had not ruled out the transfer of information within nucleic acids. He emphasised that in order to violate the central dogma, one had to find information flowing from proteins to proteins or from proteins back to either one of the nucleic acids, i.e. DNA or RNA. It was a credible argument.

Thus, for 69 years, Crick’s central dogma has been unchallenged. There have been some interesting deviations but none completely broke the rule.

A novel mechanism

Now, however, two new papers in the journals *Cell* and *Science* have reported finding a new family of bacterial reverse transcriptases. These enzymes direct cells

The discovery of DRT3b suggests that a protein can direct the synthesis of a specific DNA sequence without a nucleic-acid template, an unprecedented finding that pushes the boundaries of, but does not overturn, the central dogma of molecular biology

DNA molecules that trigger defence mechanisms, stopping the invading phage from successfully reproducing. There are several ways in which the DNA produced by DRTs stop a phage infection. Some interfere with essential phage proteins. Some activate other bacterial defence systems. Others cause the infected cell to shut itself down before the phage can multiply and spread.

The new family, called DRT3, described in these two papers, follows a novel mechanism to achieve the last outcome. According to the papers, DRT3 contains two enzymes – DRT3a and DRT3b – that work together to produce the two strands of a DNA molecule.

When this DNA accumulates inside the bacterial cell, it causes the cell to shut down and enter a dormant state,

the two DNA strands. DRT3a makes the first strand of the DNA using a bacterial RNA molecule as a template, as reverse transcriptases normally do. But the second enzyme, DRT3b, makes the second strand without using any template at all. Instead, the protein itself dictates the order of the nucleotides that determines the DNA sequence.

Interestingly, enzymes that can make DNA without a template are not new in molecular biology. One example is terminal deoxynucleotidyl transferase, which adds nucleotides to the ends of DNA without using a template. But the transferase does not add nucleotides in any specific order: if you mixed it with all the four nucleotides that make DNA in a tube, the transferase will produce a new sequence each time.

Rule challenged

DRT3b is different primarily in this regard. Although it also makes DNA without a nucleic-acid template, it does not produce a random sequence. The protein itself dictates which nucleotide is added next, producing an ordered sequence of two alternating nucleotides cytosine (C) and adenine (A), i.e. CACACACA... Despite the enzyme’s product being a simple two base pair repeat, the idea of a protein that can produce a defined DNA sequence without a nucleic acid template is unprecedented in molecular biology.

The discovery of a protein that can, by itself, dictate the sequence of nucleic acid has once again caused a stir in the scientific community.

Commentaries accompanying the work have highlighted the unusual nature of the finding and its implications for one of the foundational ideas of molecular biology. Some have gone so far as to suggest that the discovery challenges the central dogma because it appears to demonstrate information flowing from a protein back into a nucleic acid – which is just what Francis Crick had said was impossible.

However, it is important to note that while the study represents an important conceptual advance, in no way does it overturn the central dogma.

The core principle of the central dogma deals with the information lost when it is passed from nucleic acid to protein. That is, once a cell has made a protein, the protein’s amino-acid sequence will not contain enough information for the cell to rebuild the DNA sequence from which it originated. This is because there are many different DNA sequences that can encode the same protein sequence.

DRT3b also does not violate this fundamental principle governing information loss. At most, it puts a toe over the line; it does not cross it. But it does illustrate one point very beautifully: that nature is far more creative than the rules we use to describe it.

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Aerial view of a boat pulling a dead southern right whale calf in Puerto Madryn, Argentina. AFP

Scientists puzzled as whale calves wash up dead in Argentina

Associated Press

Investigators in Argentina are trying to solve the mystery of baby whales washing up dead in unusually high numbers along the country’s Patagonian coast.

Scores of the calf carcasses have been washing ashore around Peninsula Valdes, a major breeding ground for southern right whales in Argentina’s Chubut province. Hunted to the brink of extinction in the 19th and 20th centuries, the whales now gather in the peninsula’s sheltered waters to give birth and nurse their young.

“We’re looking into the whale calf deaths based on 23 years of monitoring that we have of this same population. That’s what allows us to say that this is an unusual event,” said Marcela Uhart, a veterinarian with the One Health Institute at the University of California, Davis, who is leading the investigation as head of the Southern Right Whale Health Monitoring Program.

The leading hypothesis is that the whale calves are suffering infections from marine bacteria that can enter their bodies through injuries inflicted by kelp gulls, Uhart said.

Researchers are searching for the dead calves by boat, plane and drone; they photograph and examine the carcasses, racing against decomposition to collect tissue samples for testing

For decades, the seabirds have pecked at whales surfacing to breathe, gorging on their skin and blubber. Adults learn to surface with only their heads exposed, keeping their backs underwater and out of reach of the gulls. Calves can not do that manoeuvre, leaving them vulnerable to attacks.

The carcasses have been washing ashore around the gulf city of Puerto Madryn, including near the central waterfront where they alarm residents and tourists. Residents have reported hundreds of them, but researchers declined to give a death toll, saying that would become clear after the season ends around late November.

Uhart and a team of biologists, veterinarians, and park rangers have been searching the area for the dead calves from shore and with boats, planes, and drones.

The work is gruesome: they photograph and examine the bodies, racing against decomposition to collect skin and organ samples for testing at a veterinary school farther north, in the city of Tandil. Bacteria have already been detected in those tissues, but researchers are still culturing samples to identify the microbes and determine whether infection was the cause of death, she said.

Even if bacteria are to blame, researchers must still determine why they have become so deadly this year.

Changes in marine conditions like warming sea temperatures, potentially linked to climate change or El Nino, could contribute to “this perfect storm where this bacteria is powerful enough to overcome the immunity of the babies and cause their deaths,” Uhart said. “So to the extent that we can, we’ll try to identify at least what factors may be triggering this event and making it so massive.”

Right whales got their name from whalers who considered them the “right” animals to hunt because they swam slowly, stayed close to shore and floated when killed, according to the International Whaling Commission, a global body tasked with regulating whaling.

Although illegal hunting continued into the 1970s, southern right whales have gradually rebounded since gaining international protection in 1935.

But their recovery remains threatened by the same pressures facing whales worldwide: declining food supplies, fishing gear entanglements, oil spills, and ship strikes.